

Boy Overboard



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF MORRIS GLEITZMAN

Gleitzman was born in Lincolnshire, England, but moved to Australia at the age of 16 where he worked as a paperboy, a fashion designer assistant, and shelf-stacker before earning a degree in Writing from Canberra College. Following his graduation, he began his career as a screenwriter, contributing to the success of the award-winning *Norman Gunston Show*, among others. After a decade in television, Gleitzman pivoted to writing screenplays for movies and plays before venturing into the world of children's literature. His debut novel, *The Other Facts of Life* (1987), was originally written as a screenplay, and many of his subsequent books, like *Two Weeks with the Queen*, *Blabber Mouth*, and *Misery Guts*, have since been adapted for the stage. One of his most popular books, *Bumface* (1988), is an international bestseller and continues to be one of Australia's favorite children's books, winning numerous awards. As a writer, he is known for his offbeat, humorous approach to serious subjects, such as his treatment of the Afghanistan refugee crisis in *Boy Overboard* (2002) and the AIDS crisis in *Two Weeks with the Queen* (1998). Morris published his most recent book, *Always*, in 2021, a sequel to his multi-part series, *One, Now, Then, and After*. Gleitzman's was selected as the 2018-2019 *Australian Children's Laureate*, and he has authored more than 40 children's books to date. Beyond his literary pursuits, he is a frequent columnist in the *Sydney Morning Herald* and the *Melbourne Age* and lives with his long-time partner, Mary-Anne Fahey, with whom he shares two stepchildren.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

While *Boy Overboard* is a work of fiction, its underlying narrative is loosely based on real historical events. The book aims to depict the experiences of Afghan refugees fleeing their home due to persecution, a decades-long phenomena that began in the 1970s and intensified during Afghanistan's civil wars of the 1990s. Following the U.S.'s invasion of Afghanistan in 2001, these events received widespread media attention, with news and media outlets providing constant coverage and commentary on fleeing refugees. Unfortunately, in the aftermath of the 9/11 terrorist attacks, Islamophobia and xenophobia often dominated such commentaries, with many of them falsely accusing the innocent refugees of having communist or terrorist leanings. Within this context, the plot and themes of *Boy Overboard* can be read as an attempt to challenge and reshape many of the false prevailing narratives about refugees. Like many of the real families fleeing

Afghanistan at the turn of the century, Jamal and his family are victims of persecution—likely at the hands of the unnamed Taliban—who simply wish to live a free, happy life.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Boy Overboard belongs to a genre of children's novels aimed at depicting the ordeals faced by children in the real world. Here, as in other books, he uses a unique blend of humor and relatability to portray real problems in a way that children can easily process and be inspired by. The themes of family, hope and resilience feature prominently in *Boy Overboard*, and are present in several of Gleitzman's other works. One such work is *Two Weeks with the Queen*, a novel which follows a young boy named Colin whose brother has been diagnosed with cancer. As Colin grapples with this information, he befriends an older gay man whose partner has AIDS, and the two of them help each other overcome their challenges. Another similar novel by Gleitzman is *Once*, the first book in a four-part series which follows a young Jewish boy named Felix in World War II. Like *Boy Overboard*, this book is a fictionalized account of an experience faced by many real young people in World War II, and one which highlights the importance of resilience and hope. Beyond Gleitzman's own works, other books like *Boy Overboard* would be *The Breadwinner* by Debora Ellis, a novel which explores the difficulties faced by a young girl living under the Taliban; and *Refugee* by Alan Gratz, a novel which follows three different young protagonists and their experiences as refugees in Nazi Germany, 1990s Cuba, and modern-day Syria. Together, these works highlight the incredible resilience that young people can have when faced by real world problems, offering inspiration to young readers facing their own difficulties in life.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Boy Overboard
- **When Written:** 2002
- **Where Written:** Australia
- **When Published:** 2002
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Middle-Grade Novel
- **Setting:** Afghanistan and a boat en route to Australia
- **Climax:** Jamal discovers that his parents aren't actually dead.
- **Antagonist:** The Taliban, the smugglers, and arguably the anti-immigration policies in Australia.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Taliban. Though they are never named as such, the government which forces Jamal and his family to flee are most likely the Taliban. The Taliban are a fundamentalist militant group which controlled the majority of Afghanistan from 1996 to 2001 before being overthrown by the U.S. government.

Fictional Parenting. The names of Gleitzman's two protagonists in his 2005 novel *Once*—Felix and Zeldi—were the names he wanted to call his own children.



PLOT SUMMARY

A young Afghan boy named Jamal is playing **football** (soccer) with local boys in his village. Trouble arises, however, when his sister Bibi tries to join them. Her hair is uncovered, and she is not accompanied by an adult, both of which are illegal in Afghanistan. She starts playing anyway and kicks the ball into the mine-laden desert. Jamal follows her, rescuing her and a ball from an active tank—and later, with his friend Yusuf's help, an inactive **landmine**.

When Jamal and Bibi get home, their dad reveals that their illegal school for girls has been discovered and that they need to flee the country. Jamal and Bibi spend the night in Yusuf's grandfather's house, where Jamal dedicates himself to becoming a professional football player. He believes this will make it so his family doesn't have to leave Afghanistan. He sneaks out to practice football on the street and Bibi follows him. Suddenly, their house explodes. Their dad finds them, and Jamal realizes the government was responsible for the attack. They say goodbye to Yusuf and his grandfather and Yusuf gifts Jamal his football.

Jamal's dad drives his taxi to an empty building outside the city and then leaves to pick up their mom from the football stadium. Jamal misunderstands the situation and decides to follow him. At the stadium, Jamal and Bibi see soldiers dragging women onto the field, and they realize one of them is their mom. The soldiers aim their guns at the women, but a taxi pulls into the stadium, throwing burning oil at the soldiers. Their mom gets in the taxi, and Jamal and Bibi realize their dad is the driver.

The family reunites at the empty building and Jamal helps his dad paint the taxi to disguise it. Jamal's dad sells the taxi, buying them illegal passage out of the country—the family plans to ultimately move to Australia. A smuggler carries the family out of Afghanistan and to a refugee camp, where Jamal meets a boy (later revealed to be Omar) and hears from a Red Cross worker how great Australia is. Jamal and his family board a plane and Jamal realizes that not only are the men flying the plane smugglers, but that his mother sold her ancestor's **candlestick** to buy their tickets. No one in his family seems happy, and Jamal feels their connection to the past has been broken.

Jamal and his family wait at the docks to board a boat to

Australia. Boarding the boats is chaotic—after fighting with Omar and trying to rescue the football from the water, Jamal, Bibi, and Omar end up on a different ship than Jamal's parents. Life on the boat is difficult, with little food and rampant seasickness. However, Jamal and Bibi befriend a girl named Rashida after saving her from a fire. She shares her food with them, including flour, which Jamal uses to bake bread. This lifts everyone's spirits, but not for long. Midway through the trip, the smugglers stop the boat and demand more money. Thankfully, Rashida gives the smugglers an expensive watch that's worth enough to pay for all of them—including Omar.

Bibi falls ill on her birthday and Jamal, Rashida, and Omar cheer her up with stories of Australia. Rashida reveals that she is originally from Australia, but her family moved to Afghanistan to take care of her grandparents. When the country stopped the family from returning home, her parents only had enough money to buy her way back.

A group of pirates board the boat, and Jamal disguises Bibi and Rashida as boys to protect them from being kidnapped. This ploy is successful, but when the pirates leave, the smugglers join them, abandoning everyone on the boat. The next day, a giant wave crashes onto the boat and it begins to sink. Jamal and Bibi help bail water, but they don't make much progress. Thankfully, an Australian warship arrives and saves everyone on the boat.

Andrew, an Australian serviceman, reassures Jamal and Bibi and gives them food. However, when the warship docks, Jamal and Bibi are upset to find that their parents are not there. Andrew explains that they haven't found the other boat but promises they will, and Jamal trusts him. The soldiers give the refugees tents to sleep in, and Jamal and Bibi play football against the servicemen while they wait for their parents to arrive. Soon, however, news reaches them that the other boat sank. Jamal tries to get a rescue boat launched, but none of the soldiers speak his language. Jamal also learns that the island they're on is not actually Australia.

Jamal and Bibi are devastated by their parents' death. Rashida brings them food and sits with them, but they don't want to talk or eat. Jamal realizes just how alone he and Bibi are, and when Bibi falls asleep, he goes outside to plan for their future. Omar joins him, sharing details of his own painful past. Jamal realizes that people are more complicated than they might originally seem.

Bibi wakes Jamal excitedly the next morning, telling him the three survivors from the boat have arrived. Jamal follows her to the dock and is shocked to see his parents. Their family embraces, and their parents explain that the warship didn't see them at first. They hug for a long time, and then Jamal and Bibi introduce Rashida and Omar to their parents.

Jamal talks with Andrew in his office, who apologizes for not telling him earlier about the island not being Australia. He

explains sadly that Australia's government no longer wants people from Afghanistan moving there, and Jamal consoles him. He tells Andrew that the secret of football is not giving up. Looking out the window at his family walking on the beach, Jamal feels happy and loved. Even though they're not in Australia, to Jamal, it feels like they are.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Jamal – Jamal is the protagonist of *Boy Overboard*. An 11-year-old boy, Jamal lives in Afghanistan with his mom, dad, and younger sister, Bibi. He dreams of playing professional **football** (soccer) when he is older and often practices with boys in his village. However, when the government discovers his parents are running an illegal school where they teach girls as well as boys, Jamal's family is forced to flee the country. They decide to move to Australia, where they won't be persecuted for their beliefs, a decision which Jamal is initially resistant to. As he learns more about Australia, however, he warms to the idea, eventually embracing Australia as his new home; there, he imagines an idyllic life where he and Bibi can play professional football together on the same team. Still, Jamal does not give up on Afghanistan, swearing to use his influence as a famous footballer to fix his country's problems and install a better, kinder government. This illustrates Jamal's characteristic kindness and hopeful attitude, as well as the deep connection he feels to his home country. Both his parents' families have lived in Afghanistan for centuries, and Jamal, in his quest to understand who he is and who he can be, often compares himself to these ancestors. Though Jamal initially believes he can only be like one or the other—the bakers on his father's side and the desert warriors on his mother's side—by the end of the story he realizes that there are admirable qualities in both. Jamal's notion of what 'home' means also matures by the end of the novel. Despite his ancestral ties to Afghanistan and his hopes for a new life in Australia, Jamal ultimately realizes that home is wherever family is.

Bibi – Bibi is Jamal's nine-year-old sister. Though the two are similar and share many interests, Bibi does not have the same freedoms as Jamal because of her gender. Among the activities denied to Bibi is **football** (soccer), a sport which she excels at, but which the government forbids her from playing. Being young and obstinate, however, Bibi often ignores, forgets, or outright defies the restrictions placed on girls. Because her parents have different beliefs from the government, Bibi often has trouble reconciling the way she is allowed to act inside her home with the way she is expected to act outside of it. Afghanistan expects Bibi to be demure and submissive, but she is anything but. Bibi's rebelliousness often endangers her and her family; while Afghanistan is a dangerous place for an outspoken young girl, so too is the road her family takes as

refugees to Australia. Despite the trouble it sometimes causes, Bibi's strong will also proves to be invaluable during their difficult and dangerous journey. Not only is Bibi incredibly resilient and endures starvation, drowning, and violence, in true emergencies, like the flooding of the smuggler's boat, she proves herself to be a tireless and loyal ally. As such, Bibi shows that girls are no less strong or capable than boys, highlighting the injustice of Afghanistan's conservative restrictions around gender. Like Jamal, Bibi has the steadfastness of a baker and the bravery of a desert warrior.

Mom – Jamal and Bibi's mom, or "Mum" as they call her, is a teacher in Afghanistan. She runs an illegal school out of her home with her husband, Jamal's dad, offering a full education to both girls and boys—something that the conservative Afghanistan government forbids. Eventually, however, the government discovers the school and attempts to kill her and her family, blowing up their house. While trying to warn other families about the government, she is captured and brought, along with several other female teachers, to a football stadium to be executed. Thankfully, Jamal's dad saves her, and they flee Afghanistan together with their children, deciding to move to Australia. Though this is a difficult decision for her—Afghanistan is the home of her family and ancestors—Australia has much to offer her family, and she is willing to do anything to get them there, even selling her family's ancestral **candlestick**. This candlestick had been in her family for generations, signifying good luck and safety, and her willingness to sell it testifies to her commitment to her family. Though it holds great personal significance to her, she values her family more, choosing to do what's best for them. As such, Jamal and Bibi's mother embodies the power of love and sacrifice, as well as the importance of justice and bravery. While her decision to run a school endangers her family, it also teaches them resilience and moral fortitude, traits that prove essential to Bibi and Jamal's survival during their journey to Australia.

Dad – Jamal and Bibi's dad is a taxi driver in Afghanistan. With his wife, Jamal's mom, he helps run an illegal school out of his house, one which educates both girls and boys. Like his wife, he does not agree with the government's politics, particularly around gender equality. Thus, while his wife teaches, he helps ferry female students to and from their school, highlighting his bravery and moral fortitude; despite the danger, he decides to do what is right. Still, when Jamal and Bibi's parents learn that the government has found them out, they decide to flee their home. Jamal and Bibi's father has trouble saying goodbye to their house, especially the baking oven in the basement. It had belonged to his family for generations and symbolized his connection to his baker ancestors. As much as the baking oven means to Jamal and Bibi's dad, however, protecting his family means more. This is especially apparent when he rescues Jamal's mom from execution. Not only does he risk himself to

save his wife—earning newfound respect from his son—but he also maintains a calm disposition for his children. As much as possible, he tries to shield, both literally and psychologically, his children from the dangers they face. Like his wife, he also makes great personal sacrifices to protect his family. While she sells her **candlestick** to buy them passage to Australia, he sells his taxi—and with it, his career—to pay their way out of Afghanistan. As such, Jamal and Bibi's dad shows immense selflessness, bravery, and commitment to family.

Omar/The Boy – Omar is a young boy that Jamal meets at the refugee camp outside Afghanistan. While his thievery initially offends Jamal, Omar slowly endears himself to Jamal, proving himself to be a loyal and reliable friend over the course of their journey. This begins when Bibi accidentally kicks Jamal's **football** into the water and Omar runs to retrieve it, risking his life to do so. Though he is motivated in part by his selfish desire for the ball, he is also clearly acting out of kindness. Later, Jamal and Omar bond over being separated from their parents, a bond which allows them to form a tentative, if begrudging, friendship. It is not until the pirates board the smuggler's boat, however, that Omar truly proves his worth. By stopping Bibi from attacking the pirate assaulting Jamal, Omar prevents Bibi from attracting attention to the fact that she and Rashida are girls. This likely saves both their lives, and at the end of the novel, when Omar reveals shamefully that his ancestors were thieves, it is this memory that makes Jamal realize Omar's inherent value. Though Omar clearly thinks he is just another thief like his ancestors, Jamal realizes this is not the case: a person is more than who their ancestors were. As such, Omar teaches Jamal an important lesson about the complexity of people, allowing Jamal to better understand himself and his relationship to his past.

Rashida/The Girl – Rashida is a 14-year-old girl Jamal and Bibi meet while on the smuggler's boat. Though she too is traveling from Afghanistan, she wears shorts and a t-shirt, keeps her hair uncovered, and wears eyeliner and green lipstick. Jamal and Bibi meet her in line for soup as her blanket catches fire from the flame under the pot. The three of them—plus Omar—spend the rest of the trip together and Rashida eventually reveals she is originally from Australia but spent the last few years in Afghanistan taking care of her grandparents. When her grandparents died, the government refused to let her family leave, however, and her parents only had enough money to smuggle her out of the country. Accordingly, Rashida has a lot of love and respect for her parents, and they for her. The things they pack her for the trip come in useful while on the smuggler's boat: Jamal makes bread out of the flour they gave her, and Rashida uses an expensive watch they gave her to buy off the smugglers, allowing Jamal, Bibi, and Omar to continue their trip to Australia. This highlights Rashida's generosity, as well as the strength of the bond the four children share. Without parents to watch over them, they are forced to take

care of one another, and as the oldest, Rashida plays an especially important role. Not only does she watch over all of them, but she also acts as a role model, especially to Bibi. From her, Bibi learns what a strong, confident young woman looks like, as well as how to be sympathetic even towards those who have caused harm.

Andrew – Andrew is the Australian soldier who saves Jamal and Bibi from the flooding smuggler's boat. Not only is he kind and sympathetic, but he also speaks Jamal and Bibi's language, endearing him to them and earning their confidence. When Jamal is worried about their parents' whereabouts, for instance, Andrew gives Jamal peace of mind, reassuring him that they will be found. Though he does hide the fact that the island where refugees are taken is not Australia, he does so only to protect Jamal from even more hurt, and he apologizes at the end of the book, illustrating the strength of Andrew's character. He also explains to Andrew why Australia is denying his family entry. Though Jamal does not entirely understand what Andrew is saying, Andrew's attempt to explain such a difficult concept to Jamal is admirable; instead of hiding the truth from Jamal, he treats the boy like an adult. In the end, however, it is Jamal who gives Andrew comfort, telling him the most important rule in **football** is to never give up.

Yusuf – Yusuf is Jamal's closest friend from his village in Afghanistan. Even though he lost a leg from a **landmine** accident, Yusuf loves soccer and practices with Jamal often in their village, playing the position of goalie. He is a dedicated friend to Jamal, helping Bibi get safely off the landmine, and later, gifting Jamal his **football**. Overall, Yusuf highlights the importance of friendship, as well as positivity.

Yusuf's Grandfather – After their house is blown up by the government, Yusuf's grandfather hides Jamal and Bibi in his home. There, Jamal watches **football** with him late into the night, an experience that inspires Jamal to become a professional football player. He believes if he can become famous enough, he can return to Afghanistan and reform its government. Though Yusuf's grandfather does not outright endorse Jamal's plan, his words and affection still inspire him; hearing Yusuf's grandfather explains how his people had been persecuted in Afghanistan for a long time makes Jamal realize how truly important his plan is. Thus, though Jamal only spends one night in Yusuf's grandfather's house, the experience has a lasting impact on him.

The Sailor in Yellow Overalls – The sailor in the yellow overalls is a crew member on the smuggler's ship and an antagonist of Jamal and the other children. Jamal and Bibi first meet him while trying to get help for Omar, who is drowning in the water. Instead of helping them, however, he hits Jamal and throws Bibi into the water. Though he pulls them out before they drown, the man remains an enemy throughout the rest of their journey on the boat, denying them food and demanding money from them. Bibi in particular hates him, calling him a "selfish camel-

snot,” though by the end of the story she feels more sympathetically towards him.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Mr. Nassar – Mr. Nassar is a neighbor of Jamal’s family in Afghanistan. He is an angry, difficult man, particularly after the death of his wife. In the beginning of the novel, he confronts Jamal, Bibi, and Yusuf on their way back from playing **football**, wrongfully accusing them of breaking his window.

Gav – Gav is an Australian Red Cross worker Jamal meets at the refugee camp. He is very friendly and tells Jamal about how great Australia is.

Aziz – Aziz is a friend of Jamal’s from Afghanistan. They often play **football** together, and at the start of the story when Jamal misses his shot, Aziz laughs at him.

Zoltan – Zoltan is a friend of Jamal’s from his home village. They often play **football** together, though Zoltan is a better shooter than him—a source of jealousy for Jamal.

one without **landmines** and war. For these reasons and more, Jamal begins to not only accept, but embrace, Australia as his new home. With its supposedly “nicer” government, its progressive policies, and its reportedly endless supply of food, Australia increasingly seems like an attractive place to live, and it begins to supplant Afghanistan as Jamal’s ideal image of home. By the end of the book, however, Jamal realizes home has little to do with geography, ancestry, or even government. While this realization originates in Jamal’s mother selling her candlestick, it really sets in after Jamal’s conversation with Andrew, an Australian soldier. Looking out at his family walking happily along the beach, Jamal realizes that even though they haven’t actually made it to Australia, “it feels like Australia” to him. As such, Jamal comes to understand that home is really about where one’s family is. Australia—the place Jamal has come to think of as his ideal home—can be anywhere so long as his family is there with him.



IDENTITY AND ANCESTRY

Jamal’s ancestors are both desert warriors and bakers, and for much of the book he wonders which one he is more like. To Jamal, these ancestors offer a template for his present and future, showing him both what he is and can be. Each occupation symbolizes different qualities to Jamal, and he finds himself embodying—or wishing to embody—one or the other as he navigates the various trials encountered along his journey. Early in the novel, Jamal wants to be more like his desert warrior ancestors on his mother’s side. When he’s trying to rescue his soccer ball from underneath the tank, for instance, he bemoans that he is not as brave as a desert warrior. He believes, with disappointment, he only inherited his father’s “baker genes,” which in this context, Jamal sees as significantly less useful. As the novel progresses, however, Jamal begins to realize the value of his “baking genes,” even as he increasingly proves himself to be brave like a desert warrior. For example, while bailing water out of the sinking smuggler’s ship, Jamal thinks of how tirelessly his father’s baker ancestors worked to bake bread, beginning at three in the morning every day—something that inspires Jamal to keep bailing water, even when it’s difficult and exhausting.

Ultimately, Jamal realizes that a person’s ancestry doesn’t have to dictate who they are in full. At the end of the novel, Omar, for instance, reveals that his ancestors were thieves. Though Omar has stolen before, Jamal realizes that he has also been far more than this; on countless occasions, he has proven himself a selfless friend and ally. Thus, when Omar asks Jamal about his own ancestors, Jamal answers that he is a little of both his parent’s ancestors: he’s part baker, part desert warrior. Jamal realizes that who a person is more complex than who their ancestors were or where they came from, and so he decides he can be too. In this way, *Boy Overboard* suggests that, while one’s past can offer a useful template for self-actualization—as



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



IMMIGRATION, FAMILY, AND HOME

Boy Overboard follows young Jamal’s family as they leave Afghanistan to seek asylum in Australia.

Persecuted by the Afghan government for running an illegal school, Jamal and his family are forced to flee their country. This is a traumatic experience, as Jamal’s family has deep ancestral ties to Afghanistan, they’re an integral part of their community, and Jamal dreams of being able to stay and “fix” his country’s government. As such, leaving Afghanistan is more than just leaving behind a house; it is leaving behind an entire identity, community, and support system. This is the symbolic significance of Jamal’s mother’s candlestick: it represents their connection to Afghanistan. Thus, when Jamal’s mother sells the candlestick to buy them passage to Australia, it feels to Jamal like his family is severing its connection to its past and identity.

However, despite Jamal’s family’s close ties to Afghanistan, in many ways the Australian way of life aligns better with their beliefs and dreams. For instance, while in Afghanistan Bibi was barred from playing football (soccer), in Australia she will be able to play without fear of persecution. Moreover, Jamal and Bibi will both be able to receive proper (and legal) education in Australia, as well as grow up in a safer environment—that is,

it does for Jamal—it does not need to be wholly prescriptive.



HOPE

As Jamal and his family flee Afghanistan to seek asylum in Australia, they are all motivated by the hope that they'll be able to make better, safer lives for themselves outside of Afghanistan. Hope, *Boy Overboard* suggests, is a powerful motivator—it can give people the strength to make difficult changes, and for young characters like Jamal and Bibi, it can allow them an escape from the horrors of their lived experiences. Jamal's parents decide to seek asylum in Australia after the Afghan government discovers their illegal school, setting the family off on a dangerous journey to cross the border out of Afghanistan and then book passage on ships bound for Australia. Their hopes are mostly practical: keep the family safe and together, goals they cannot achieve in Afghanistan once the government discovers their school.

Jamal shares his parents' hopes, but hope takes a slightly different form for him, as a child: hope is an escape. After learning his family must move to Australia, Jamal commits himself to becoming an extraordinary football player, imagining that, if he becomes successful enough, he can use his influence to fix his country and install a new, kinder government. With a better government in place, Jamal believes his family will be able to return without experiencing persecution. In this way, football gives Jamal a sense of agency at a time when he has little control over his life. When things seem bad, Jamal can practice football and feel like he's making a difference. Additionally, Jamal daydreams about playing on famous international teams to mentally escape the frightening experience of being separated from his parents on a ship bound for Australia. In these dreams, not only is Bibi playing alongside him (which she couldn't legally do in Afghanistan), but his family is reunited and happy. His dreams represent his hopes for his family's future in a place where Bibi can reach her full potential despite her sex, and his family is happily reunited. And though Jamal's dreams don't all come true by the end of the novel—the family doesn't reach Australia, and he's not yet a famous player—*Boy Overboard* nevertheless highlights hope's ability to provide comfort during difficult times.



GENDER AND DISCRIMINATION

In *Boy Overboard*, Jamal and his family are acutely aware of the fact that girls and women don't have the same rights or opportunities as boys and men in Afghanistan. The government forbids girls from receiving education, leaving the house without a male escort, and most annoyingly for Jamal's sister Bibi, playing football (soccer). *Boy Overboard* makes it clear that these rules are nonsensical: as Bibi and Rashida, an older girl Jamal meets on the ship,

demonstrate, girls are just as intelligent and capable as their male counterparts. But though Bibi and Jamal resent the implication that girls are lesser than boys, they nevertheless must navigate a society—both in Afghanistan and on the ship to Australia—that discriminates against girls and women, something that in turn makes women particularly vulnerable to violence.

Bibi's journey highlights the injustice of gender discrimination. Not only is it unfair, but it also makes inaccurate assumptions about the innate abilities and dispositions of boys and girls. For instance, Bibi is the exact opposite of what the conservative Afghan government thinks a girl should be—instead of docile and obedient, Bibi is headstrong, outspoken, and independent. She is also a talented athlete: despite stereotypes around girls' athletic abilities, she proves herself to be an excellent football player. In fact, she's even better than her brother. As such, she often forgets or ignores the rules the Afghan government places on girls, which puts her and her family in danger. Later, Jamal and Bibi discover that this danger doesn't end when they leave Afghanistan: when pirates in league with the smugglers board Jamal and Bibi's ship and begin taking women on board with them, Jamal immediately recognizes that his sister and Rashida are in danger. By disguising them as boys and beginning a soccer game (playing on the stereotype that girls aren't good at sports), Jamal is able to keep his family and friend group together. Thus, while *Boy Overboard* consistently shows that gender roles aren't innate and often harm girls and women, it also suggests that playing into them can, in some cases, offer safety and protection.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE CANDLESTICK

Jamal's mom's **candlestick** is a symbol of hope, luck, and family history. As long as a candle is burning in it, Jamal's family believes that the candlestick serves as a protective charm, warding off misfortune. When Jamal and Bibi leave to find their parents at the **football** stadium, for instance, they leave a candle burning in the candlestick. After their mom returns safely, she expresses her gratitude for the lit candle, crediting the candlestick for her good fortune. By lighting a candle in the candlestick, Jamal and his family believe they are channeling their ancestors' goodwill and the guidance of their forbears. Thus, when Jamal's mom sells the candlestick to buy passage to Australia, Jamal feels as though his family's connection to Afghanistan has been severed. The candlestick, in this context, symbolizes their ties to the past, and without it, they feel the loss of that connection.



JAMAL'S FOOTBALL

Jamal's football embodies his dreams, hopes, and aspirations. Throughout his journey, he often envisions himself playing on one of Australia's professional teams, sharing the field with Bibi—something which would be impossible in Afghanistan. This vision sustains him during his difficult travels, motivating him to keep moving forward. In this regard, Jamal's football represents not only his athletic aspirations, but also his hope for a better life in Australia; through football, Jamal believes he can create a better future for his family.

However, Jamal's football also symbolizes his deep connection to Afghanistan. Gifted to him by Yusuf, a friend from his home village, the ball connects him to his past and reminds him why he wanted to become a professional football player in the first place—to return home and help fix his country. As such, Jamal's football is the symbolic bridge between his old life and his new beginnings, embodying his dreams for finding a better life in Australia and, ultimately, an improved Afghanistan. With the football by his side, Jamal can have hope for the future while preserving his ties to the past.



LANDMINES

Landmines symbolize **Jamal's** trauma. On his journey from Afghanistan to Australia, Jamal is often haunted by his memory of landmines. Though landmines are not a threat in the areas he is traveling, whenever confusion arises, or people show distress, he suspects landmines are the culprit. This is an ingrained response, the product of growing up in war-torn land peppered with landmines. Because of this, Jamal has come to view them as a constant threat, even when they are not. In this regard, landmines in *Boy Overboard* symbolize not just war, but the enduring trauma it creates. Just as landmines continue to be dangerous even after the end of a conflict, Jamal's trauma associated with them lingers, even when landmines are no longer a direct threat to him.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker)

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 1

Explanation and Analysis

While playing football (soccer), Jamal notes the absence of smoke, nerve gas, and explosions. He explains that “bomb wind” can affect one's ability to play football well and is happy that he is able to play undistractedly. Though he does not say so explicitly, it is clear from his tone that such disturbances are a normal part of his life. To him, something like a sandstorm or explosion is just as ordinary as a game of football with his friends. While plenty of children would be scared or disturbed by such dangers, they have been normalized for Jamal; he sees them as little more than passing annoyances, the way another child might view a thunderstorm. While on one hand this highlights the horrors of war, it also illustrates Jamal's grit and adaptability. It is awful that Jamal should have to endure and normalize such daily horrors, yet it is also inspiring that he is able to accept and move past them so easily. This also illustrates that Jamal is truly just a kid like any other: despite the threat of bombs and nerve gas, Jamal just wants to play soccer with his friends.

“The others are still backing away and looking at me and I realize I have to do something. This person who is putting us all in danger is a member of my family. [...]

Bibi must have forgotten that girls aren't allowed to leave the house without a parent. She must have forgotten that females have to keep their face covered at all times out of doors. And it must have slipped her mind that girls playing football is completely, totally and absolutely against the law.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 4

Explanation and Analysis

Bibi has joined in with Jamal's friends to play



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Puffin edition of *Boy Overboard* published in 2003.

Chapter 1 Quotes

“I'm Manchester United and I've got the ball and everything is good. There's no smoke, or nerve gas, or sand-storms. Which is really good. Bomb wind can really put you off your football skills.

football—something that she’s not allowed to do, and which scares Jamal’s (male) friends. As a girl, Bibi does not have the same rights as boys in Afghanistan. Unlike Jamal, she is unable to leave the house unaccompanied, have her face uncovered outside, or play football. These laws are designed to control and disempower women by denying them the same freedoms as men. As is the case at the start of the story, these restrictions often put Bibi and Jamal in challenging situations, underscoring the harmful consequences of gender discrimination.

For Bibi, these restrictions seem unfair and nonsensical; raised by liberal parents in Afghanistan, she has been taught that girls and boys are equal and should be able to do the same things. Though the government has made many things illegal for girls—like playing football or receiving an education—Bibi’s parents have resisted these restrictions within the walls of their home, such as by establishing a secret school for girls. Thus, Bibi is forced to live in two very different worlds, and she often has trouble transitioning between them. Though she often resists the restrictions placed on her, like showing up to play football with Jamal and his friends, doing so is dangerous and puts her and her family’s lives at risk.

Though they do not affect him like they do Bibi, these restrictions are also difficult for Jamal to navigate. When Bibi tries to join their soccer game, for instance, Jamal feels conflicted: as her older brother, he feels an obligation to enforce the law (for their safety), but he also takes pride in her soccer skills and genuinely wants to play with her. After all, he was the one who initially taught her to play, and it feels wrong to deny her the opportunity to practice and showcase her talents. In this way, Jamal also feels the negative effects of gender discrimination, as he is forced to choose between following laws with which he fundamentally disagrees or disobeying them at the risk of endangering his family.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞☞ I slump back, weak with despair. Who am I kidding? I didn’t inherit anything from Mom’s ancestors. Bibi got all the desert warrior genes. All I got were Dad’s. The strength, courage, and fierceness of a baker. Pathetic.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

Jamal bemoans his lack of bravery in his confrontation with the tank, linking it to his ancestry. He believes that his inability to retrieve his ball from beneath the tank signifies that he has only received his father’s “baking genes” and none from his mother’s “desert warrior” ancestors. This underscores not only the importance that ancestors play in Jamal’s self-perception, but also the preference he places on his mother’s ancestors over his father’s, especially at moments like these. Though he knows there is value in his father’s baker genes—as he notes earlier, bakers are honest and hard-working—he is more attracted to the idealized image of the desert warriors and feels “pathetic” when he is not able to live up to their bravery.

There is also a hint of jealousy towards his sister here. Bibi is undeniably fierce and courageous, having thrown rocks at the tank just moments before, and Jamal clearly wishes he could have more of her tenacity. Though Jamal’s relationship toward his ancestors changes and matures as the story progresses, this passage highlights the deep symbolic importance they hold for him, and the internal conflict he experiences when measuring up, or falling short of, their legacy.

Chapter 5 Quotes

☞☞ “I hate this whole country,” says Bibi after a while. “This country is camel snot.”

I’m shocked.

Nine-year-old kids shouldn’t hate their country. They should love their country and want it to do well in the World Cup and earn the respect of other nations so they’ll stop bombing us.

Related Characters: Jamal , Bibi (speaker), Bibi, Yusuf

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

After her close call with the landmine, Bibi expresses her hatred for Afghanistan, shocking Jamal. Though Bibi’s hate is not unwarranted—as a girl, she is often treated unjustly in her country—Jamal does not want her to hate Afghanistan, believing that kids should love their country. This desire is more idealistic than accusatory, however, as Jamal does seem to not blame Bibi for her feelings. After all, she has just escaped death from a landmine and blames her country for allowing such dangers to threaten its citizens. Rather,

Jamal's wish that Bibi love Afghanistan is more a reflection of his own complicated relationship to his country. While he harbors a deep love for Afghanistan and values his ancestral ties to it, he also clearly wishes it had the respect of other nations. He believes that, were it to do well in the World Cup, it might finally win the admiration of the rest of world, spelling the end of war in his country.

This sentiment reveals a lot about Jamal's character, as it highlights his hopeful persistence and the connection he sees between football and national identity. Though Afghanistan is plagued by war, conflict, and inequity, Jamal sees past these issues, believing in the inherent goodness of his country and the possibility for improvement—a possibility rooted in football. This sentiment forms the seed of Jamal's eventual plan to become a famous football player and reform his country. However, this also reflects his youth and immaturity. A successful soccer team on its own won't totally fix Afghanistan's international problems, but as a child, Jamal doesn't understand the particulars of what's happening.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☹☹ 'We've got to get out of the house,' he says. 'Tonight. And we can't ever come back.'

I feel like a landmine has exploded next to my head. My brain can hardly take in the words.

Related Characters: Jamal , Dad (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

Jamal is devastated by the news that his family must leave their home, likening his reaction to that of a landmine exploding by his head. While he was expecting to be punished for his actions earlier in the day, his parents' revelation blindsides him—so much so that he struggles to really process the information. Jamal's choice of simile is particularly revealing in this regard, for it illustrates the intensity of shock, fear, and confusion that Jamal is feeling. The gap between his expectation and this new reality is so great that the words themselves almost lose meaning, like the mind-numbing ringing one experiences when one is nearby an explosion. Having narrowly avoided being killed a by landmine just hours earlier adds even more weight to his

comparison; Jamal is fully aware of the devastating, deadly power of a landmine. His feeling of shock is so palpable it seems deadly.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☹☹ I wish I could go to the city and get the government out of bed and tell them what they're doing to our family. How they've made my mum cry. How they've stopped me from getting lino. But I can't. I don't even know where the government lives.

Related Characters: Dad (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 40

Explanation and Analysis

Still reeling from the shock of his parents' revelation that the family must leave the country, Jamal tries to think of a solution that would allow his family to stay in Afghanistan. Though he is not entirely ignorant of the danger his family is in, his proposed solution highlights his naivete. Not only does he imagine the entire Afghanistan government sleeps in one bed—as though it were a single entity or individual—but he also assumes the government would change its stance if it simply understood the impact it was having on his family, such as making his mom cry or preventing him from getting a lino (linoleum) floor. These assumptions highlight the profound disconnect Jamal has from the complex political reality of his world, and they underscore his inability to grasp the full gravity of the situation. He knows his family is in trouble, but his understanding and solutions are that of an 11-year-old.

Still, Jamal's desire for resolution—and the nature of the solution he proposes—tells a lot about his character. For one, it exposes Jamal's strong emotional ties to his home country; despite its many problems, Jamal's love for Afghanistan is unwavering and he yearns to continue living there. While admittedly naïve, his plan also reveals his underlying assumption of goodwill among the people of his country, even those persecuting his family. He does not believe that people in his country could harbor ill will towards one another and assumes that the conflict between his parents and the government must be based in misunderstanding. This is, of course, not true, as Afghanistan forbids girls from getting an education and Jamal's parents are running a secret school for girls. There's

no misunderstanding in what's going on, in this sense: Jamal's parents are breaking the law, and the government will punish them for that.

Chapter 9 Quotes

💬 A wonderful thought hits me. We can do it together. We can improve our skills and impress the government and start a national team and win the hearts of Afghans together. When the government sees how talented Bibi is, they'll change their minds about girls playing football. They'll have to.

Related Characters: Dad (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 45

Explanation and Analysis

While playing football with Bibi in the street, Jamal realizes happily that she can join him in his plan to become a professional football player. She is just as talented as he at football—if not more so—and he is optimistic that, after showcasing her talent to the world, the government will change its laws around women playing football. Though this sentiment highlights Jamal's naivete around the politics in his country (as well as his and his sister's skill level at football), it also showcases his incredible generosity and goodwill. Not only does he harbor no resentment or jealousy towards his sister for her natural talent at football, but he goes so far as to involve her in his dream—even if it means she might one day overshadow him.

More broadly, Jamal's plan underscores the lack of control he feels over his current circumstances. He is upset about having to leave home, and his solution—unrealistic though it may be—offers him a way to take back some control of his life. Instead of helplessly ruminating on the challenges facing his family, he can practice football, believing he is doing something to improve their circumstances. At a moment when his life is in shambles, his dream of becoming a football player gives him a sense of hope for the future, grounding his identity with a sense of direction and purpose.

Chapter 11 Quotes

💬 If Mum and Dad are really going to convince that government football official, they need us there too.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 57

Explanation and Analysis

Believing his parents are meeting at the football stadium to pitch his and his sister's football skills to government officials, Jamal reasons that he and Bibi should join them. In reality, their dad is going to rescue their mother from being executed, but Jamal is too innocent to consider such a possibility. Even though his father gives them money and instructions in case he fails to return—actions which imply danger—Jamal optimistically assumes his parents have had the same train of thought as he and wants to help them. This is a classic example of Jamal's well-intentioned naivete. Though he is not entirely oblivious to the danger his family is in, Jamal's misunderstanding illustrates that Jamal has yet to fully grasp the full weight of the situation. He still operates in the world of an 11-year-old, imagining that the conflict between his parents and the government can be resolved by something as simple as a display of football skills. Psychologically, Jamal's belief is also just how he copes with things that scare him and that he doesn't understand. He clearly has yet to process—and accept—that he and his family are leaving their home, and he is looking for every opportunity to imagine an alternative reality.

Chapter 13 Quotes

💬 We look at each other. And suddenly I know that if Dad can be a desert warrior in the football stadium, so can I.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 69

Explanation and Analysis

Having witnessed his dad's brave rescue of his mom from executioners in the football stadium, Jamal realizes that, even though his dad's ancestors are bakers, this does not preclude him from acting like a desert warrior. This is a less fatalistic, binary stance than the one Jamal held previously.

Where before he believed a person could only inherit the genes from one side of their family—earlier, he suggested Bibi got all the desert warrior genes and he got all the baker genes—seeing his father’s heroism has made him more open-minded in the way he thinks about ancestry and his own relation to it. If his father can act like a desert warrior when he’s actually descended from a long line of bakers, Jamal realizes he can, too.

This revelation illustrates Jamal’s burgeoning maturity, as well as the positive influence his family has on him. Though new obstacles have presented themselves to Jamal, the guidance of his parents—both spoken and by example—have allowed him to adapt and grow. With his father leading by example, Jamal has been able to shed some of his childish beliefs about identity and ancestry.

☝ ‘If a person goes somewhere else and becomes a huge football star,’ I say to Yusuf’s grandfather in my imagination, ‘and so does his sister, and they play regularly on TV, and then they come back to Afghanistan with their parents, do you think they’d be popular enough to help form a new government? A kind and fair government that wouldn’t murder anyone?’

Related Characters: Dad (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad , Yusuf’s Grandfather

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 70

Explanation and Analysis

Jamal speaks to an imaginary version of Yusuf’s grandfather, asking him whether becoming a football star will allow him to return to Afghanistan and form a new government. Having witnessed his dad rescue his mom from execution, his understanding of the world and his country has dramatically shifted. While he previously believed his football skills would be enough to win the favor of the Afghan government, after the horrifying events at the football stadium, Jamal no longer maintains such delusions. He has finally come to terms with the reality of his family’s predicament, and his aspirations have shifted accordingly. While he still dreams of becoming a famous football player, he no longer imagines that this dream will materialize in Afghanistan. Instead, he focuses on making his dreams come true in Australia. His motivations for becoming a

famous football player have shifted as well. No longer does he just want to the government to stop being “cross” with his parents; having seen the government attempt to execute his mom, Jamal now wants to not just return to Afghanistan, but reform it, too. In this sense, Jamal’s new dream reflects his loss of innocence since being targeted by the government. Though he is as optimistic as ever, he no longer understands the world in the same overly simplistic terms as before.

Chapter 14 Quotes

☝ I feel like crying too, but instead I reach out and touch my rucksack. I want to check that my football is still packed safely. Just because I’ve never heard of any Australian football teams doesn’t mean there aren’t some good ones. I want to get all the practice I can on the way there, so I’m ready.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Mom , Yusuf

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 74

Explanation and Analysis

Though he is sad about leaving Afghanistan, Jamal finds consolation in the comforting presence of his football, carefully packed away in his rucksack. As a gift from Yusuf, the ball holds a special place in Jamal heart, connecting him to his past in Afghanistan, just as his mom’s candlestick connects his family to their ancestors. In this way, the ball becomes a piece of home that Jamal can take with him on his journey to Australia.

The football is more than just a relic from his past, however: it is also as a symbol of hope for his future life in Australia. Jamal dreams of returning someday to Afghanistan as a famous footballer to reform his country, and the ball acts as a bridge between his present condition and that ideal future. It anchors his identity and purpose, reminding him that if he practices hard enough, moving to Australia does not necessarily mean bidding a permanent goodbye to Afghanistan. Because of its symbolism, the football provides Jamal with a feeling of hope, even at a time of great emotional turmoil.

Chapter 17 Quotes

☹☹ I stand frozen, frantically trying to think how to help Dad. The police all have guns. Any sudden movements could be fatal. But I have to do something because if I don't, Bibi will, and I'd rather have me shot than her.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 88

Explanation and Analysis

Seeing his father surrounded by police, Jamal's tries to think how he can help. He believes—incorrectly—that the government intends to arrest his dad, and despite the personal risk to himself, he takes action, reasoning that if he doesn't, Bibi will. She has a record of acting impulsively, and Jamal would rather him get shot than she. This underscores not only Jamal's perceptiveness (at least regarding Bibi's personality), but also his incredible selflessness and loyalty; he is willing to die if it saves Bibi. This parallels Jamal's response earlier in the book when Bibi steps on the landmine. Instead of waiting idly on the sidelines, Jamal jumps into action, trading places with Bibi on top of the landmine plate. Here, Jamal does the same thing, confronting the police officers even though he knows "any sudden movements could be fatal." Though he rarely gives himself credit for it, this shows incredible bravery on Jamal's part and exemplifies the qualities he associates with his desert warrior ancestors. Moments like this show that Jamal is too hard on himself, as he often bemoans his lack of courage in trying circumstances. This scene illustrates that, contrary to his self-perception, Jamal is far braver than he gives himself credit for.

This passage also highlights Jamal's youth and how little he understands of what's going on around him. Though he believes these men his dad is talking to are police, they're actually smugglers who are going to get Jamal's family out of the country and to Australia.

Chapter 18 Quotes

☹☹ We're not protected any more. We're about to get on a plane and place our lives in the hands of smugglers and our ancestors aren't protecting us anymore.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

Jamal fears that, without his mother's ancestral candlestick (which his mom sold to buy passage to Australia), his family is no longer protected. Like the rest of his family, Jamal believes that the candlestick, when lit, functions as a protective charm against misfortune. Passed down for generations, it functions as a conduit between Jamal's family and his mother's ancestors, and without it, Jamal fears that this connection has been cut. This is a particularly jarring revelation for Jamal, as he has just boarded a plane for the first time in his life and, more than ever before, feels his family needs the protection of their ancestors.

More broadly, this moment underscores the sacrifices Jamal's parents are making to ensure their family's safety. Just as his father sold his taxi to buy them safe passage out of Afghanistan, his mother sells her cherished candlestick to buy them tickets to Australia. These items have great sentimental and spiritual value to Jamal's mom and dad, and their willingness to part with them illustrates the depth of affection that they have for their children, and the value they place on keeping their family together.

Chapter 19 Quotes

☹☹ As the plane lurches on into the night, I realize this is what we're going to have to do from now on. With no candlestick to look after us, we're going to have to look after each other.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 101

Explanation and Analysis

Contemplating the loss of his mother's ancestral candlestick, Jamal realizes that his family will have to start looking after one another in its stead. Though this notion is self-evident to his parents, this revelation is a pivotal moment in Jamal's emotional development. Not only does it illustrate an increased willingness to shoulder more responsibility to support this family, like entertaining Bibi or

providing emotional support to his mom, but it also underscores just how quickly Jamal has learned to adapt to new and trying circumstances. Only hours after being crestfallen about his mother's sale of the candlestick, Jamal has already found a way to approach the loss that allows him to maintain a positive, forward-thinking attitude. Just as Jamal adapted his dreams of becoming a football player in Afghanistan to the reality that his family is moving to Australia, here he adapts to the loss of spiritual connection to his homeland, embracing the fact that familial support will have to supplant ancestral support. This is a necessary emotional evolution for Jamal, as he learns to prioritize what is truly important in life and to make the necessary sacrifices—either emotionally or physically—to protect those things.

Chapter 22 Quotes

☹☹ I want to go back to Australia. I saw it. Green football pitches and goalposts of solid gold and little stools for one-legged goalies to sit on. Me and Bibi winning the cup final for Dubbo Abattoirs United. I was there. Now I'm here on this deck shivering.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 113

Explanation and Analysis

Jamal yearns to return to the idyllic vision of Australia he had while drowning. Though it is the result of nearly dying from asphyxiation, Jamal's vision of Australia is a welcome escape from the dreary, frightening world of reality. Filled with happy visions of football and family, it seems a far better alternative to the world he is living in. This shows that, though he has tried to maintain a positive, hopeful outlook since leaving Afghanistan, the stresses of his journey have caught up to him and he is in dire need of relief.

Though it is clear from the vision that Australia has replaced Afghanistan as the place where Jamal imagines a happy future for his family, Jamal never says so explicitly in the waking world. This suggests that dreams—or hallucinations—can reveal hidden or unacknowledged truths. Jamal's subconscious yearning for his dream Australia, for instance, reveals the true extent of his

suffering. Even though it would mean his death, Jamal momentarily wishes he could remain submerged in the water, drowning instead of returning to the real world.

Chapter 23 Quotes

☹☹ A desert warrior could swim over there and grab the other boat's anchor chain in his teeth and swim back dragging the other boat behind him. But I'm not a desert warrior. I'm just a kid trying to keep his family in one piece.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 118

Explanation and Analysis

Watching his parents' boat sail out of sight, Jamal reflects on how a desert warrior would be able to pull the two boats back together. Instead of bemoaning his inadequacy, however, Jamal reflects realistically on who he is and what he is capable of: a kid trying to keep his family together. This marks a significant shift in Jamal's perspective and self-perception, as it signals a departure from his previous, childish worldview. While before he might have bemoaned the gap between his own abilities and those of the idealized desert warrior, here he accepts who and what he is, shedding his prior feelings of shame about his limitations. Instead of beating himself up over that which he cannot control, he decides to focus on what he can control, like ensuring his and Bibi's safety. This shows great personal growth for Jamal: confronted with the harsh realities of the life of a refugee, he has become more realistic in his expectations for himself. He cannot afford to waste energy on the question of whether he deserves the title of desert warrior; he now has more important things to think about.

Chapter 24 Quotes

☹☹ And freeze in shock myself. It's a teenage girl. All she's wearing is shorts and a T-shirt with a sparkly pattern on the front. Her arms are bare. Her legs are bare. Her hair is completely uncovered and sticking out in all directions. She's wearing makeup. She's got black stuff on her eyelashes and her lips are green. I've never seen anything like her in my life.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom, Dad, Rashida/The Girl

Related Themes: **Page Number:** 121**Explanation and Analysis**

Jamal is shocked by the appearance of the girl (Rashida) he saved from the fire. Not only is she showing skin on her arms and legs, but her hair is uncovered, and she is wearing makeup. For someone raised in Afghanistan, where such things are illegal, this is a startling sight. Not only is it rare to see a woman or girl dressed like this, but in Afghanistan, it is also dangerous. When Bibi arrived at the soccer field with her hair uncovered, for instance, Jamal and his friends were terrified; they feared a government official will see her and implicate them in her crime. Thus, even though Jamal has been raised by liberal parents who do not support the government's restrictions of women's bodies, he has been culturally conditioned to be alarmed by someone dressed like the girl is dressed.

It is to Jamal's credit, then, and to his mom and dad's parenting, that his shock does not become fear or dislike. Instead, Jamal quickly accepts the girl as she is, eventually befriending her. This shows Jamal to be incredibly open-minded and generous of spirit, extending his assumption of goodwill to people who look different than him or who practice different customs.

●● A pirate stops right in front of us, studying the ball as it goes back and forward. I pray he doesn't know how brilliant females can be at football. I pray he assumes anyone with knee skills like Bibi and Rashida must be male.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Rashida/The Girl**Related Themes:** **Related Symbols:** **Page Number:** 143**Explanation and Analysis**

Pirates board the smuggler's ship and Jamal, fearing Bibi and Rashida will be kidnapped, dresses them as boys and begins a game of football. This is quick thinking on Jamal's part, illustrating not only a newfound appreciation of their vulnerability as child refugees, but also a complex understanding of the stereotypes surrounding gender. Though he personally knows it isn't true, Jamal reasons that the pirates will assume anyone practicing football is a boy. In

this way, he uses the pirates' bigotry against them to protect his sister and his new friend.

This moment also displays the sense of responsibility that Jamal feels toward the other children. In lieu of any parents, all four of them are forced to take care of one another, and so just as Rashida sells her watch to buy off the smugglers, Jamal devises a way to conceal Bibi and Rashida's gender from the pirates. This illustrates that age is not necessarily a sign of maturity or responsibility; though they are young, Jamal and the other children take great care of one another.

Chapter 32 Quotes

●● A lot of the men down here are looking at her. They can't believe a female can keep going this long. They don't understand how she can do it. I know how. Her father's a baker.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Dad**Related Themes:**   **Page Number:** 148**Explanation and Analysis**

Jamal proudly notes the attention Bibi's hard work bailing water receives from the men on the boat. Despite her exhaustion, she continues to help bail out water from the sinking ship, a display of grit and determination that the other men are unaccustomed to seeing in women. Jamal's attributes her tireless dedication to their father's ancestors, the bakers, who would wake up at 3:00 a.m. every morning to do the exhausting work of baking bread. This illustrates Jamal's newfound appreciation for the values embodied by his father's baker ancestors. Though previously Jamal had belittled the "honest" "hard work" of the bakers relative to the bravery of his mother's desert warrior ancestors, here he sees its value in action. Though it may not be flashy, the reliable, tireless effort of his father's ancestors proves essential in moments like this, and for the first time Jamal expresses pride in the resilience he inherited from his father's side of the family.

Chapter 39 Quotes

●● Bibi's asleep at last. That's why I'm lying out here on the football pitch. So I don't disturb her while I try and plan our future. It's hard to plan quietly when you're crying. I don't want to think about the future. I don't want to think at all. But somebody's got to do it and Bibi's only ten.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Bibi, Mom , Dad

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 148

Explanation and Analysis

Having recently arrived in what he believes is Australia and learned that their parents have died, Jamal goes out to the football pitch to plan for his and Bibi's future. She has finally fallen asleep, and he doesn't want to wake her with his own crying. Though he does not want to think about the future, he realizes that the responsibility rests on his shoulders as the eldest child. This illustrates the profound transformation Jamal has gone through on his journey as a refugee. Following the example set by his parents, Jamal has learned to put aside his own troubles and emotions for the sake of his family; just as his dad suppressed his emotions to protect Bibi and Jamal from worrying about their mother, Jamal tries to suppress his to plan for their future. Recognizing that breaking down like Bibi has would put their lives in jeopardy, Jamal takes up the mantle of responsibility, even though he does not want to. Thus, while he is only a child, Jamal assumes the role of guardian for Bibi, taking over for his parents.

☞ 'One lot were desert warriors,' I say. 'The other lot were bakers.'

'Which are you?' says Omar.

I think about this. I think about the things that have happened. My chest fills with grief again, because suddenly I know the answer it makes me miss Mum and Dad so much.

'I'm a bit of both,' I say.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Mom , Dad , Omar/ The Boy

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 172

Explanation and Analysis

When asked whether he is more like his mom's or his dad's ancestors, Jamal answers that he is a "bit of both." This marks a significant turning point for Jamal, as it is the first time he openly embraces both sides of his ancestry. This reflects the transformation he has undergone because of his

journey, shedding the naive ideas he held as a child. Previously, Jamal believed he could only embody qualities from one side of his family or the other, favoring the desert warriors on his mother's side. Yet he often felt he fell short of their legacy, and so he worried that he only inherited his father's "baker" genes.

Now, however, Jamal realizes that his identity does not have to directly map to either side of his parent's family. Over the course of his journey, he has come to appreciate the value of both sides of his family's heritage and has recognized both sets of values—the bravery of the desert warriors and the resilience of the bakers—in himself at various points. Seeing that both have proven useful in different circumstances, Jamal has come to realize that his previous understanding of his ancestry was misguided.

Chapter 42 Quotes

☞ Down on the beach I can see Mum and Dad and Bibi walking together at the water's edge. Even though they're picking their way through plastic bags and rotting seaweed, they look so happy my chest fills with love and I feel so lucky. I know this isn't really Australia, but it feels like Australia to me.

Related Characters: Jamal (speaker), Mom , Dad

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 181

Explanation and Analysis

Reunited with his family at last, Jamal reflects on the true meaning of home. Though he has learned that the island he and family are on is not actually Australia, Jamal realizes that the meaning he had previously attached to Australia—a place where he and his family can start a new, happy life—is not exclusive to the literal boundaries of the actual country of Australia. Rather, he comes to think of Australia more as a state of mind, one that sees him feeling happy, loved, and safe with all of his family members present and accounted for. This illustrates not only Jamal's emotional development, but also underscores the transformative effect of trauma.

For much of his journey as a refugee, Jamal had attached his hopes for a better, happier, life to the image he had constructed of Australia, believing that if only his family could get there, all would be well. However, after the trauma of believing his parents to be dead, Jamal's priorities undergo a profound shift. He realizes that the actual country of Australia has nothing to do with the idyllic vision

he had of his family's future. Such a life can be found

anywhere, he believes, so long as his family stays together.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Jamal plays **football** (soccer) with his friends. His team pretends to be Manchester United, and the other team pretends to be Newcastle United. Jamal has the ball, and he happily notes that there is no smoke or nerve gas or sound of explosions. He explains that bomb wind can be distracting while playing football. Jamal is known primarily as a good dribbler and passer, but he wants to shoot. His friend Zoltan calls to him to pass, but Jamal ignores him. He shoots, but the shot goes awry and the ball rolls toward Yusuf, the goalie, who recovers it easily. Jamal's friend Aziz calls the shot "weak," while Zoltan looks at him in disbelief. Jamal apologizes, but realizes his friends aren't listening; they're distracted by something behind him.

Jamal is worried that they are in trouble with an Afghan official for playing **football**. When he looks behind him, however, he sees his sister, Bibi. Wanting to join the game, she starts dribbling the ball, but the boys back away. Jamal realizes he must do something: Bibi has forgotten that, as a girl, she is forbidden to leave the house alone, have her face uncovered, or play football. If officials see her with the ball, Jamal worries that their parents will be dragged off by the government. He tells his friends to tackle her and take the ball away, but they are unable to. She is too good at football, which Jamal taught her to play inside their house.

Bibi dribbles toward the goal and takes a shot. Yusuf dives for the ball, but it goes in the goal anyway. Bibi and Jamal grin proudly one another, but then Jamal remembers he needs to be sterner with her when she breaks the rules. Everyone except Yusuf leaves, however, because the ball has rolled into the rocket crater in the desert. Before Jamal can stop her, Bibi runs to retrieve the ball. Yusuf tells Jamal to follow her, and Jamal sprints after Bibi. He realizes that she has forgotten why people don't go into the rocket crater.

The opening lines of the story establish how normalized the effects of war are in Jamal's country. Though Jamal is not dissimilar from many kids his age around the world, he must worry about things that most kids don't, like smoke, nerve gas, or landmines. For him, however, such dangers are so commonplace that they register more as annoyances than serious threats. He just wants to play football with his friends and dislikes it when war interrupts their game. This illustrates the incredible adaptability of children to their environment, as well as Jamal's deep love of football.



This passage illustrates the control that the Afghanistan government exercises over the day to day lives of the Afghanistan people, and the psychological harm that such control can inflict. Children must worry about retribution for something as simple as playing football, and female citizens like Bibi are denied simple joys and freedoms, like playing sports or leaving their house alone. Here, Jamal is faced with the difficult choice of enforcing the government's unfair laws, or endangering him, his friends, and his family by allowing his sister to play football with them. Though he is proud of his sister's football skills—he taught her himself—he does not want his parents or friends to get into trouble.



Bibi scores on Jamal and his friends, highlighting her natural talent and underscoring the unfairness of the government's restrictions. She is just as good, if not better, than Jamal and his friends. This moment also illustrates her willful, rebellious personality. Though the government forbids her from playing football, she does anyway.



CHAPTER 2

Jamal calls for Bibi to watch out for the **landmines**. He tells her to stay still and begs silently for her to be safe. He cannot find her, but he knows a landmine has not gone off because he would have heard it. He realizes how far Bibi must have kicked the ball, and he finally spies her running across the desert. The ball is stopped against an abandoned tank. Following her footsteps, Jamal catches up with Bibi, who angrily asks why he followed her. Her feelings are hurt that Jamal thought she could not get the ball herself.

Jamal makes up an excuse for why he followed her, claiming that their parents will be worried if they're not home soon. Bibi says they won't because she left them a note saying she went to play **football**. Jamal is shocked and tells her they need to rip up the note. If someone finds it their parents will be in trouble—almost as much trouble as if they were caught for running an illegal school.

Jamal runs to grab the ball, but when he gets close to the tank he realizes it is not abandoned, it's just parked. The gun barrel turns to point directly at him, and Jamal is terrified. He tells Bibi to run, hoping the tank won't shoot at them. Instead, Bibi begins to throw rocks at the tank, yelling at it to return their ball.

This scene illustrates the sense of responsibility that Jamal has for his younger sister. Because of her impulsive, willful personality, he has to watch out for her safety, even if his concern often goes unappreciated. Here, for instance, Bibi is hurt that Jamal followed her into the desert. Unaware of the threat of landmines, she believes he didn't think she could retrieve the ball herself, offending her sense of independence.



Sensing her hurt, Jamal makes up an excuse for why he followed her, illustrating his protective, kind nature. He does not want to hurt her pride. However, Jamal is upset about the note Bibi left behind. Given their parents' illegal activities, Jamal does not want to give the government any reason to investigate them. Once again, Bibi's thoughtless impulsivity endangers their family, and Jamal is forced to take care of it.



Bibi reckless rebelliousness is on full display here. Instead of cowering from the tank, she begins to throw rocks at it, demanding it return their ball. Though Jamal's family seems to encourage Bibi to be independent at home (despite the government's wish that she be demure and quiet), her rebellious nature once again puts her and Jamal in danger.



CHAPTER 3

Jamal yells at Bibi to get down, but she keeps throwing stones at the tank. Eventually she lies down, but when the tank does not shoot them, they decide to stand up. Jamal tells Bibi to run home to help Yusuf—who only has one leg—while he gets the ball back. Jamal remembers what his mom told him about her desert warrior ancestors and tries to channel their bravery, asking the tank to return the ball, claiming that **football** is going to be his career. The tank does not respond, however, and Jamal goes to remove the wedged ball from under the tank.

Jamal's run-in with the tank makes him think of his mother's ancestors, the desert warriors. To him, they represent bravery, and he tries to channel them to muster up the courage to retrieve the ball from the tank. This illustrates the importance Jamal attaches to his heritage, and the impact that his ancestors' identity has on own self-perception. Because they were desert warriors, he believes some part of him can be a desert warrior, too.



Jamal is not strong enough to pull the ball from under the tank. He feels pathetic and screams at the tank, bemoaning his lack of bravery. He believes Bibi got all the desert warrior genes and that he only has the bravery of a baker. After his screaming, he feels hot and wonders if he will die. Suddenly the tank starts to drive away, leaving without running over the ball. Jamal grabs the ball, thanking both his warrior and baker ancestors. He hears a scream in the distance, however, and starts running back towards Bibi. Yusuf yells that Bibi has stepped on a **landmine**.

Jamal's relationship to his desert warrior ancestors sours with his inability to retrieve the ball. Though he favors the desert warriors on his mother's side, he believes he only inherited his father's baker genes, and feels shame that he is unable to live up to the desert warrior legacy. This illustrates Jamal's immaturity, not only for being too hard on himself—he is taking on a tank after all—but also for his overly simplistic approach to identity.



CHAPTER 4

Jamal makes his way back to Bibi, reassuring himself that the lack of an explosion is a good sign. He finds Bibi and sees that she is unhurt; however, she is standing on a **landmine**, with one leg pressing down the metal plate. If she moves it, the bomb will explode. Bibi explains that it's her fault, not Yusuf's (who Jamal had begun to blame). She saw something for her bird migration project at their parent's illegal school and accidentally stepped on the mine. She is terrified, and Jamal tells her to trade places with him.

Once again, Bibi's recklessness has gotten her into trouble. Sidetracked by finding something for her project, she accidentally steps on a landmine, and Jamal and Yusuf are forced to find a solution. Being the responsible, loyal big brother that he is, however, Jamal does not blame her, offering instead to trade places with her.



Yusuf points out how dangerous changing places is, and Bibi refuses to move. Jamal tries to convince her, claiming that if she blows up, their parents will get in trouble for her being out of the house. Bibi is obstinate, but she eventually concedes. They trade places without an explosion, and Yusuf and Bibi leave to get help. Jamal looks at the mine and notices that it is new. This is a good sign because new bombs are less volatile and easier to deactivate. Bibi runs back, saying she doesn't want to leave him. She runs into his arms, knocking them both over, but the bomb does not explode. Jamal feels faint and sick, but he's thankful they both survived.

Bibi's obstinance proves problematic once again, though this time it is to protect her brother. She does not want him to take her place on top of the landmine, and it is only after much negotiation that she agrees to trade places. However, her decision is short-lived, and her recklessness nearly kills them again, running into his arms and knocking them both off the landmine.



CHAPTER 5

Jamal, Bibi, and Yusuf sneak into the village. Bibi is disguised as a boy, but she keeps loudly insulting their country and Jamal worries she will attract attention. He doesn't like her hatred of Afghanistan, as he believes that kids should love their country. Thankfully nobody notices them, and they make it to the front of their house. Before they can enter, however, Mr. Nassar, their neighbor, confronts them and wrongfully blames them for breaking his front window. They deny it, and Jamal shows his skills with the **football** to prove he's too good to make such a mistake. Bibi makes a commotion, however, and Jamal gets distracted, kicking the ball through Mr. Nassar's other window.

Bibi continues to cause problems for Jamal and Yusuf, and Jamal is concerned by her hatred of Afghanistan. Jamal feels that children should be rooting for their country, not against it. His experience is different from Bibi's however, being a boy. He does not experience the same level of discrimination she does, and he enjoys many freedoms she does not, like playing football. In fact, much of Jamal's patriotism is linked to his love of football, a love which Bibi shares but cannot partake in the same way Jamal can, being a girl. While Jamal can dream of becoming a national football player for Afghanistan, Bibi cannot.



Mr. Nassar threatens to call the police, but thankfully Jamal and Bibi's father arrives. He apologizes for their mistake and promises to pay for the windows. He notices that Bibi is there, but pretends she is another boy, promising Mr. Nassar that the other "boys" will be punished by their parents. Mr. Nassar is intimidated by the fierceness in their father's eyes, which Jamal's explains is really fatigue from his long hours driving the taxi. Their dad pulls them all into the car and drives down the street, dropping off Yusuf. Jamal hopes his father will wink to show he isn't angry, but he doesn't.

Jamal and Bibi's dad quickly resolves the conflict with Mr. Nassar, cleverly covering for Bibi's presence. This shows him to be not only resourceful and quick thinking, but also respected within the community. He approaches conflict calmly, but with confidence. This foreshadows their father's adept dealings with various figures later in the story.



CHAPTER 6

Jamal and Bibi wait in the living room for their parents to scold them. Bibi apologizes for causing the problem, and Jamal says it's okay and compliments her on her goal. Jamal hopes that their parents are happy Bibi got exercise playing soccer, but when he sees their expressions, his hopes fades. Instead of scolding them, however, Jamal and Bibi's parents give them both a big hug and tell them how much they love them. Their mom is crying, and Jamal does not understand why; he guesses that she is sad about their dead relatives. Then their dad tells them they have to leave their house that night and never return.

Despite her troublemaking, Jamal shows incredible kindness to Bibi, forgiving her for getting them in trouble and complimenting her on her goal. This underscores Jamal's generosity of spirit as well as the love he feels towards his sister. This display of familial affection is replicated when Jamal's parents embrace their children. They have bad news, and they want to cushion it with love.



Jamal is shocked and thinks his parents are overreacting. He thinks it's about getting in trouble with Mr. Nassar, but their dad says it's far more serious than that. Jamal then guesses that it is about the petrol their dad bought from another taxi driver, but their mom explains that the government found out about the school. Jamal realizes that their living room does not have any of its normal school supplies in it. Jamal thinks he knows how the government found out: every day, their dad transports girls to and from their home, and someone must have seen them. Their father hugs them again and says it's too risky to stay; they have to leave immediately.

Ironically, Jamal believes his parents are being naïve about the severity about the problem at hand. In reality, Jamal does not understand what is going on, illustrating his disconnect from the adult world. He does not realize that his parents would not move their family for something as minor as a neighborly disagreement, or some illegal petrol purchase. Though he is not oblivious to the dangers his family faces in Afghanistan, his understanding of the world is still a childish one.



CHAPTER 7

Jamal and Bibi are shocked and angry about having to leave their home. Bibi starts to cry, and their mom hugs her, pulling out her ancestor's **candlestick** for good luck. She tells Jamal to pack, and Jamal sadly realizes all the things he cannot take with him. He follows his dad to the basement and sees him say goodbye to an oven that has been in his family for generations. Jamal realizes his mom is in the basement too, burying the school supplies. Jamal starts to cry but then sees the painting of him scoring a goal in the World Cup Final. He looks like a desert warrior in the painting, and Jamal becomes determined to find a way to stay.

Jamal and his family struggle with the task of packing up their home and possessions. His father says goodbye to his family's ancestral oven in the basement, and his mother says goodbye to her school supplies. For Jamal, leaving turns out to be too much to process, and he decides to find a way to stay in Afghanistan. This underscores his immaturity, for he naively believes he can succeed in finding a way to stay in Afghanistan where his parents cannot.



CHAPTER 8

After packing, Jamal and Bibi spend the night at Yusuf's grandfather's house. Jamal watches a **football** game with Yusuf's grandfather. Since Yusuf's grandfather's TV uses illegal satellite, the game is in English and Jamal asks what the announcer means by "overboard." Yusuf's grandfather explains the meaning of the word and offers to let Jamal sleep on the mattress. Jamal is too worked up to sleep, however, and he decides to come up with a plan to stay in Afghanistan. Inspired by the football on the TV, Jamal asks Yusuf's grandfather if the government would forgive his parents if he got very good at football.

Yusuf's grandfather grabs Jamal's shoulder and tells him he is a good boy, but that things are difficult for people like them. He explains that most people in the country don't like them, and it has been that way for a long time. Jamal knows this already, as his mom says this, too. Yusuf's grandfather starts to cry, and Jamal grows more determined to carry out his plan. He thinks if he can become the star of Afghanistan's **football** team, his family and people like his family will never be hurt or bullied again.

Inspired by the football game on TV, Jamal devises a way for his family to stay in Afghanistan. He reasons that if he can become a good enough football player, the government will have to let him and his family stay. Though well-intentioned, this plan illustrates a naïve understanding of the real danger he and his family are in. Jamal has yet to accept the reality that his family must leave Afghanistan, and his plan is a coping mechanism that allows him to resist change for now.



Yusuf's grandfather offers insight into the complex politics of Afghanistan society, suggesting that people like Jamal and his family face discrimination. Though it is not explicitly stated, this is likely a reference to the social rift between the Taliban—the terrorist group running Afghanistan at the time—and the Shia, a Muslim minority group in Afghanistan to which Jamal's family likely belongs. Hearing this, Jamal becomes more convinced to carry out his plan, extending his ambitions to not only help his family, but also people like his family.



CHAPTER 9

Jamal practices **football** in the street. It is the middle of the night, and he realizes what a good time it is to practice: unless he makes noise, no one will arrest or imprison him. He also cannot sleep, and practicing takes his mind off things. Bibi shows up, however, and accuses him of sneaking out. She asks where their parents are, and Jamal explains—without actually knowing—that they are warning the parents of the other schoolchildren.

Bibi says she wants to play **football** and then steals the ball from Jamal. Jamal realizes what a natural talent Bibi is and decides to include her in his plan: together they can become famous football players. Then the government will have to legalize girls playing, too. Bibi takes a "penalty shot" and kicks the ball hard down the street. It lands in front of their old home, and just as it does, their house explodes. Jamal and Bibi are thrown to the ground, and villagers emerge from their homes. Their dad shows up and pulls them to their feet, cursing the trucks driving away from their home. Jamal realizes that the trucks must have created the explosion, and that the government blew up their home.

Set on becoming a famous footballer, Jamal practices football on the street. This illustrates that, apart from providing him with hope, Jamal's dream also offers him a way to cope with the upsetting changes in his life. Not only does it distract him, but it also provides him with a sense of agency and control over his life. Though unrealistic, Jamal imagines that practicing will ultimately allow him to win back the government's favor.



This passage highlights Jamal's love for his sister, as well as his selflessness. Though it is his dream to become a famous football player, he has no issue sharing the dream with Bibi, nor does he harbor any jealousy for her natural talent. This scene also illustrates to Jamal and Bibi the extent of the danger they are in. Watching his house explode is a wake-up call that the government might not be as open to negotiation as Jamal hopes.



CHAPTER 10

Jamal and Bibi's dad carries them inside Yusuf's grandfather's house. They ask where their mother is, and their father explains that she will meet them the next day in the city. Yusuf's grandfather reports that villagers are still outside, but that the taxi in the alley has not been discovered. Jamal and Bibi's dad says it's time to go and thanks Yusuf's grandfather. Jamal says goodbye to Yusuf and tries to give him his ball, but Yusuf refuses, telling him Jamal needs it where he's going. Yusuf says he will miss Jamal, and Jamal nods his agreement, too choked up to speak. In the taxi, Jamal reassures Bibi that they will see their mom soon and that their family will always stay together.

This passage underscores the selflessness of Yusuf and his grandfather. Though harboring criminals puts them in danger, they do not think twice about assisting them. This is particularly true of Yusuf who, recognizing the turmoil Jamal must be going through, gifts Jamal his football. Even though footballs are hard to come by, Yusuf recognizes that Jamal has a greater need than him, showing great generosity. This scene also illustrates the responsibility that Jamal has as an older brother. Though he is also concerned by his mother's absence, he hides his own misgivings and tries to comfort Bibi.



CHAPTER 11

Jamal wakes as their dad drives the taxi off the road. They stop beneath "tape-trees"—telephone poles covered with confiscated cassette tapes—and stretch their legs. Their dad leads them to an abandoned shop and explains he's going to pick their mom up at the **football** stadium. Privately, he gives Jamal money and instructions for returning to their village in case he does not return. Jamal and Bibi have breakfast, and Jamal tries to cheer her up with football stories. Suddenly, Jamal realizes that their parents must be telling the government how good they are at football so that their family can stay. Jamal thinks it would help if he and Bibi were there, too.

Leaving the familiarity of his home village, Jamal encounters "tape-trees" along the road—which highlight the government's censorship and oppression. Though this is a clear illustration of the government's radical intolerance, Jamal is still hopeful that he and his sister can convince the government to let them stay and believes his father has the same idea. This suggests that Jamal has yet to truly accept the reality of his family's predicament. Though it seems unlikely his father would be trying to talk to the government about his children's football skills, Jamal cannot yet accept the alternative. He needs to believe there is still a way to stay in his home country.



CHAPTER 12

Jamal and Bibi arrive at the **football** stadium. There are lots of people around and Jamal tells Bibi there must be a match taking place. He believes national selectors will also be there and imagines how happy they will be to meet him and Bibi. They cannot find their parents, however, and they push further into the stadium. Bibi calls out for their parents, and Jamal reminds her that they don't want to attract attention; they are on a death list after all. Jamal is amazed to find that the stadium doors are open. They go inside to look for their parents.

Jamal follows his father to the stadium, still believing he'll be auditioning for the national selectors. Though there are signs that something is amiss—like the open stadium doors and the absence of their parents—Jamal's optimism overpowers his doubts. This displays a considerable degree of cognitive dissonance; though he recognizes that his family is on a government death list, he still maintains his belief that the government will be impressed enough by his and Bibi's soccer skills to let them stay in the country.



Jamal and Bibi climb to the top of the stadium seats. An army truck drives into the stadium and soldiers drag several women—they know because they're clothed from head to toe—out from the back of the truck. Jamal and Bibi believe it is a warning from the government about letting women play **football**, and that the guns are fake. Still, they are scared. A woman breaks away from the soldiers and Jamal and Bibi recognize her as their mom. The soldiers grab their mother and point rifles at her head, and Jamal realizes that these women must all be illegal teachers.

The soldiers point their guns at the teachers' heads, and Jamal begins to run down toward his mom to save her. Bibi joins him and the rest of the crowd follows suit, though Jamal realizes they are not running to rescue the women; they don't want to see an execution. Suddenly a taxi drives into the stadium throwing cans of burning oil at the soldiers. The taxi knocks down the soldiers holding their mom and opens the passenger door. She climbs in and the taxi takes off. Jamal and Bibi realize that the taxi driver was their dad.

Slowly, Jamal and Bibi realize that the football stadium is not being used for tryouts, but rather for a public execution. As such, Jamal's hope turns to dread, especially after recognizing his mother among the to-be-executed. This is a harsh wake-up call that the world is neither as friendly nor as simple as Jamal had previously imagined. As the tape-trees from the previous chapter hinted at, the government does not tolerate disobedience from its people, and their mother's illegal school is no exception.



Here, Jamal shows incredible bravery and loyalty. Though there is realistically nothing he can do to save his mother, he still runs down the stadium to try and stop the execution. His reaction is immediate and instinctual, suggesting that he may be more of a desert warrior than he realizes. Even against impossible odds, Jamal tries to protect those he loves.



CHAPTER 13

Jamal and Bibi return to the shop, but their parents are not there. Jamal reassures his sister that their dad is just making sure they're not followed. Jamal packs everything to go, except for their mom's **candlestick** which has a candle burning in it for good luck. Their parents arrive in the taxi, and the family embraces. Bibi reveals they were at the **football** stadium, but their mom is not upset and thanks them for having a candle burning in the candlestick. Bibi asks what will happen to the other women, and Jamal replies they could not do anything for them; they are "just a family." Their mom promises they will stay a family, no matter what happens.

Bibi asks where they are going, and their mom tells her they're going someplace "a long way away." Jamal goes to help his dad, who is painting the car red. As they work, Jamal tells his dad he and Bibi could have helped in the rescue attempt. His dad is touched and tells Jamal he is proud he is his son. Jamal's dad reveals he is going to sell the taxi, and Jamal realizes what a great sacrifice he is making. Jamal imagines another conversation with Yusuf's grandfather. In it, he asks whether becoming a famous **football** star would allow his family to come back to Afghanistan and start a new, kinder government, and Yusuf's grandfather says yes. Jamal promises to do it.

This passage highlights the power of family as a safeguard against harm. Upon returning safely to the abandoned shop, for instance, Jamal and Bibi's mother thanks them for lighting her ancestral candlestick; she believes lighting it harnesses the goodwill and protection of her ancestors, and she attributes the part of the success of her rescue to it being lit. However, tragically, this passage implies that the other female teachers at the stadium weren't so lucky and were executed, highlighting the government's cruelty and control over its citizens.



After his traumatic experience at the football stadium, Jamal adjusts his plan for becoming a famous football player. Having witnessed firsthand the cruelty of the government, as well as the true danger facing his family, Jamal reorients his plan around the idea of returning to fix Afghanistan, instead of winning back the favor of the government. While still idealistic, this shift in Jamal's dream illustrates a step towards a more realistic worldview. He does not want to fully give up on his country, but he also recognizes the need for his family to flee.



CHAPTER 14

Jamal and his family hide under sacks in the back of a smuggler's car. After being asked several times, their dad finally tells them where they're going: Australia. Jamal and Bibi are shocked by the news. Jamal doesn't know much about Australia, but he does know it's far away and that it doesn't have a team in the English Premier League. Men on the road then stop the car. Jamal and Bibi overhear a conversation about money between the men and the driver and hope that the men don't find them in the truck.

The men let the car pass. Their dad says goodbye to the country, and Jamal realizes they've crossed the border out of Afghanistan. Jamal's dad holds his hand from the backseat. Their mom cries, and their dad comforts her. Jamal checks his rucksack to make sure his **football** is still safe. Even though he hasn't heard of any Australian football teams, he believes there might still be good ones and he wants to practice. He feels the **candlestick** inside his mom's bag, and he thanks her ancestors.

Jamal and Bibi are shocked by the news that they're moving to Australia. As is typical, Jamal immediately thinks of football, reflecting on the fact that Australia does not have a team in the English Premier League. Once again, football becomes the means by which Jamal processes the changes in his life, relating the unfamiliar to something he loves and understands.



Jamal and his family cross the border out of Afghanistan. While the rest of his family expresses grief, Jamal tries to ground himself in familiarity, feeling for his football and his mother's candlestick through his rucksack. The first provides him with a sense of hope for the future, while the second gives him a sense of security in his family and in his identity.



CHAPTER 15

The crowd at the refugee camp is the largest Jamal has ever seen, including at the European Cup Final on TV. Jamal's family has been there three days trying to find a way to get to Australia. Jamal tries to help, though no one takes him seriously, so he spends a lot of time practicing **football**. At the camp, people are constantly trying to sell things, though luckily Jamal's mom packed well so they don't have to buy anything. A boy trying to sell Jamal water agrees to play ball with him, but he steals the ball and Jamal chases after him. When Jamal finally recovers the ball, he realizes he is in a different part of camp.

Jamal notices that the people in this area of camp are lying down. He thinks they're sick and wonders how he might be able to help them. When he sees a truck with a red cross on it, he stops it and points out to the driver all the sick people. The driver corrects him, saying they're just hungry and that they're waiting for a food shipment. He asks if Jamal wants to help hand out food, and Jamal says yes, if he's still here. He says he's going to Australia. The man introduces him to Gav, a blond-haired Australian man.

Jamal's experience at the refugee camp reveals the fact that his family is not alone in their struggles. There are thousands of refugees, and everyone is looking for the same thing: a better, safer future. This highlights the extent of persecution in Afghanistan, and the harm that it can cause. People in the camp are desperately trying to make ends meet, selling personal items and even stealing.



Jamal's naivete takes center stage here, with him believing the starving people in the camp are sick instead of hungry. Still, despite his naivete, Jamal displays incredible selflessness and compassion. Though he is only a kid, he takes it upon himself to stop a Red Cross truck and ask for help for the people. Then, when he learns the people are starving, he offers to help distribute food when it arrives.



Jamal asks him what it's like in Australia and whether there are any good **football** teams. Gav says there are and that girls are also allowed to play soccer. Jamal is delighted by this and asks more questions, like whether people can be bakers and whether there's enough food for everyone. The man answers yes to all his questions. He says that people are always happy in Australia. Jamal is proud of his parents for having them move to the best place on earth. Jamal tries to return to his tent, but realizes he is lost. He tells himself not to give up hope but thinks that sometimes, there's nothing else you can do.

After speaking to the Australian Red Cross worker, Jamal feels much better about moving to Australia, renewing his faith in his parents' decision. As is typical, however, Jamal's reaction is overly optimistic and idealized; he has just learned of Australia, and already he believes it is the best place on earth. This highlights the extent of Jamal's emotional turmoil: he so desperately needs hope that he over-idealizes any opportunity that offers the slightest glimmer of it.



CHAPTER 16

Inspired by his dad's ancestors, Jamal comes up with a plan to bake bread. He reasons that the smell of bread will attract his dad, and that he can also feed the hungry people with it. He soon realizes how hard the supplies will be to get, however, and he gives up, feeling hopeless. Suddenly, the boy who stole his ball grabs Jamal by the hand and promises to lead him to his family. They negotiate a price for the exchange—a dollar, and then Jamal's ball—but eventually the boy just helps him anyway.

Jamal's reasoning for baking bread reveals his childish optimism and goodwill. Though his plan to attract his father with the smell of bread is impractical, it underscores his compassion and generosity: in addition to helping him find his family, he reasons he can also use the bread to feed the hungry people.



The boy leads Jamal to two United Nations men giving out tickets out of camp. There is a huge crowd, however, and the men don't hear Jamal's pleas for tickets. Eventually, the men get back into their car and drive off. Like everyone else, Jamal calls for them to come back, but they don't. Jamal decides to show off his ball skills to the United Nations men the next morning. He walks around looking for the boy but can't find him. Then, Jamal spies his family's tent, but something is wrong. His mom and Bibi look worried, and he sees his dad surrounded by policemen.

Jamal's relationship to the boy who stole his ball becomes more complex. Though the boy fails in his promise to bring Jamal to his family, he still seems interested in helping him, bringing him to where the UN is selling tickets to leave the country. Jamal also reveals his childishness here, believing that his football skills will be enough to impress the UN into giving his family tickets.



CHAPTER 17

Believing the government has found his dad, Jamal approaches the police and pleads with them not to arrest him. He promises his dad won't start another school and that they're going to Australia. His dad's expression confuses him, however; his dad is giving pleading looks to Jamal, not the police. Jamal's mom shows up and tells him it's alright, and Jamal notices her face is uncovered. Jamal sees his dad hand the police money, and he realizes his dad is paying them not to arrest him. Jamal is relieved but wonders where his dad got all the money.

Like with the football stadium incident, Jamal misinterprets the situation at hand, believing his dad is being arrested when he is actually making a deal with what seems like smugglers. Again, Jamal acts impulsively, pleading with the police officers/smugglers not to arrest his dad. Though Jamal misunderstands the situation, these actions show Jamal to be not only loyal, but brave. Even though he is only a kid, he is willing to confront policemen if it might mean saving his dad.



The police take the money and leave. Jamal's mom asks his dad when they're leaving. Jamal is confused and his mom explains that those men can get them to Australia; that was what the money was for. Jamal is thrilled and tells Bibi all the exciting new things he learned about Australia. Despite the good news, however, Jamal's mother looks sad. Jamal is confused by this and speculates that she must be missing her friends from home. Bibi thinks it must be some bad news they haven't been told yet.

This passage underscores Jamal's disconnect with the events happening around him. Not only does he fail to understand what is happening between his father and the smugglers, but even after learning the truth he still fails to understand the money for the tickets came from, or why his mother is so upset. Though Jamal is undoubtedly maturing, he still does not fully understand the world of adults.



CHAPTER 18

Jamal has never been to an airport before; he's only seen them on TV. Unlike on TV, there is no waiting room with amenities. They drive directly onto the runway. Everyone is relieved, as they've been traveling by bus the entire night, though Jamal's mom still seems unhappy. When they get off the bus, the driver drives off, leaving them alone on the runway. Everyone looks worried, and Jamal's mom says she hopes they can trust the smugglers. Jamal realizes that the men helping them are not from the UN.

Jamal attempt to relate his new experiences with his existing knowledge leads to disappointment. As is the case here, Jamal's expectations fall flat of reality. Though he expects the airport to be like the airports he has seen on TV, the two could not be less alike. This passage also highlights the uncertainty and the danger that Jamal's family faces by working with smugglers. They can book passage out of the country relatively quickly, but it seems uncertain whether they'll get out safely—or indeed, if they'll actually get out at all.



They decide to wait on the plane, but before they can board several security guards run over and stop them. They scan their bags for metal objects and Jamal worries that his mother's **candlestick** will set it off. No alarm goes off, however, and Jamal realizes that the candlestick is gone: his mom sold it to buy their passage to Australia. Now he understands why she is so unhappy. They're about to be smuggled into Australia by dangerous men and they're no longer protected by their ancestors.

Jamal learns that his mother sold her candlestick to buy them passage on the smuggler's plane, underscoring the depth of her love for her family. Though the candlestick is a priceless family heirloom with great spiritual importance, she is willing to part with it to protect her family. It is this sacrifice that allows them to escape the fate of the other refugees stuck at the camp.



CHAPTER 19

The plane takes off, but no one in Jamal's family seems happy. Jamal thinks of Yusuf and vows to buy him an amazing **football** when he gets to Australia. The plane is old and rickety, and Jamal worries that it cannot handle the flight. Other passengers seem scared too, and Jamal thinks it was careless of the flight attendants to tell everyone about the safety features before taking off. Jamal's mom looks nervous, and Jamal reassures her it will be okay because the plane has guns to protect it against attackers.

For Jamal and his family, the flight is not one of relief and relaxation. Though they are closer now to Australia than ever before, they have sacrificed much to be where they are, and their future is still uncertain and scary. Jamal shares in these worries, but he also tries to alleviate them for the rest of his family, highlighting his selflessness and compassion. Sensing his mom's nervousness, for instance, Jamal attempts to reassure her about the plane's safety.



Jamal's mom tells him that it does not have guns because it is a passenger plane. Jamal thinks this is an oversight on the part of the plane builders; if the plane costs so much, they might as well add guns. Bibi says the plan probably has bombs, but Jamal explains, patronizingly, that it's a passenger plane: it does not need bombs if it has guns. Jamal's mom looks more relaxed, and Jamal is glad he was able to calm her down. Jamal realizes that, without the **candlestick**, everyone in his family will have to look after one another.

Jamal and Bibi have a childish fight over whether the plane has guns or bombs. The squabble seems to have a calming effect on their mother, though Jamal assumes it is because of his logical reasoning. More likely, Jamal's mother is calmed by the sense of normalcy her children bickering creates. Though everything in their life has changed, Jamal and Bibi are still fundamentally the same children they were before.



CHAPTER 20

Jamal thinks the smugglers are treating them badly. They've been waiting on a dock the entire night and have been given only one meal a day. Jamal's dad looks worried but reassures Jamal that they are safe from Afghanistan's government now. Still, Jamal thinks they won't be safe until they get to Australia. He believes that if it lets girls play **football**, the government must be nice. There are two boats in the water, and Bibi keeps asking which one is theirs. Their mom looks annoyed, but she manages to keep her composure and offers to blow on Bibi's rash to cool it off. Their dad tells them to be patient.

Jamal's family is tense as they wait for the next stage of their journey to begin. Taxed by the stresses of their journey, everyone in the family struggles with their own problems, but they do their best to manage them for the sake of the others. Jamal's parents, for instance, try to maintain a calm, positive attitude for the sake of Bibi and Jamal, even though they themselves are quite worried.



Jamal is worried they won't all fit on the boats, but he reassures himself that they bought tickets. He distracts himself by looking at the boats and how large the ocean is, comparing it to the desert. Bibi asks when they can get on the boat, and Jamal takes her to practice **football** to give his parents a break. The other refugees watch in shock as Bibi practices, and Jamal is proud of her. Suddenly, the boy from the refugee camp tackles him and claims the ball is his. Jamal and Bibi argue, and Bibi starts yelling at the boy. The boy looks shocked at a girl acting that way and lunges at Jamal to steal the ball.

Though he is himself quite young, Jamal tries to support his parents by entertaining and watching over Bibi. This shows that, at least when it comes to his family, Jamal is not entirely naïve. Sensing that his parents need a break from Bibi, he takes it upon himself to distract her by playing football. In this way, Jamal takes on a pseudo-parental role.



While struggling with Jamal for the ball, the boy says they can have the ball if Bibi becomes his girlfriend. Bibi gives the boy a nasty look and kicks him in the leg. Jamal and the boy continue struggling over the ball, and the ball slips out of their grasp. Before the boy can grab it, Bibi kicks the ball. It flies over the compound fence and lands between the boat and the dock. Everyone gasps.

Again, Bibi's righteousness and impulsiveness prove problematic. Though her unfaltering commitment to following her conscience is commendable, it often causes more problems than it solves, as is the case here. While the boy is wrong to steal Jamal's ball and make jokes about dating Bibi, kicking the ball away only exacerbates the situation.



CHAPTER 21

Jamal realizes that everyone gasped because the gates to the boats opened. Jamal tries to forget about the ball, focusing on bringing Bibi and himself back to their parents. Their parents are being pushed towards the gate by the crowd and Jamal tries to catch up with them. Once they're through the gate, Bibi goes after the ball, moving away from their parents. Jamal chases her and finds her unsuccessfully trying to retrieve the ball from the water. She says they need it for their dream of becoming soccer players to come true. Jamal agrees but does not want to lose their parents.

The boy from earlier shows up and says he'll get it if they "go halves." He climbs down to the water to get closer to the ball, putting himself in danger of being crushed by the boat. He slips and falls into the water and Jamal screams for help. No one hears him, however, so he runs to a sailor in yellow overalls. Jamal explains the situation, but the man does not understand. Jamal grabs the man's pole, and the man smacks him in the face, prompting Bibi to kick and bite the sailor. He picks her up and throws Bibi off the side of the boat.

Despite his emotional attachment to the football, Jamal focuses on the more important task of reuniting his family. Bibi, however, being younger and more stubborn, rashly chases after the ball, separating them from their parents. This illustrates that, while the qualities Jamal reveres in desert warriors are important--like bravery and courage--they can also be problematic if not checked by other qualities, like patience.



The relationship between Jamal and the boy who stole his football continues to get complicated. He seems to insert himself into Jamal and Bibi's life at every opportunity, though his motivations for doing so are unclear. As is the case here, it almost seems as though he wants to help or be friends, but just doesn't know how to do so. Jamal approaches the sailor in a way that suggests he believes the people smuggling them on the boats are kind and trustworthy. But throwing Bibi overboard suggests that once again, Jamal may severely misunderstand the situation.



CHAPTER 22

Jamal jumps into the water after Bibi. The water is cold and green, and he has trouble swimming. He sees her in the water next to him but has trouble keeping them both afloat. As he runs out of breath, he sees Australia in his mind. Then something pulls him up to the ship and he can breathe again, though he can no longer see Australia. He sees Bibi next to him on the boat and pulls her close. The sailor in the yellow overalls grins at him and unhooks his hook from Bibi's clothes.

Jamal wants to go back to the Australia he saw while drowning. He and Bibi were winning the cup final in it, and now they're on a boat. Jamal remembers his parents and calls out to them. He doesn't see them, however, and he discovers that they're on the other boat. He calls out to them across the water, and they see Jamal and Bibi. They are shocked and their dad begins to jump into the water, but their mom stops him. The distance between the boats increases and Jamal calls for the other boat to come back.

Without any hesitation, Jamal jumps into the water to save Bibi, proving once again that he is often too hard on himself. While he may think he falls short of the legacy of his desert warrior ancestors, moments like this suggest the contrary. Here at least, he exhibits incredible bravery and courage.



Jamal's wishes to return to the vision he has of Australia while drowning, revealing the extent of his suffering in the waking world. Though he has tried to stay optimistic since leave Afghanistan, the stresses of his journey have caught up with him, and he clearly desires some sort of escape. Thus, though it would spell his death, Jamal is tempted to stay in his idyllic vision of Australia beneath the water.



CHAPTER 23

Jamal calms Bibi down, promising to radio the other boat to turn around. They look for smugglers but can't find any. The sailor in the yellow overalls confronts them and Bibi starts hitting him again. He starts to come for them, but a large smuggler with hairy arms stops him. Jamal explains their situation to the new smuggler, but the man says they don't have radar or radio. Jamal wants to chase the other boat, but the man tells him to be quiet or he'll throw them both off the boat.

Bibi is angry, and Jamal tries to calm her down. He says if they anger the smugglers they won't get to Australia and won't see their parents again. Jamal looks at the other boat and thinks about how a desert warrior could swim to the other boat, pulling this one along behind him. Jamal says he's not a desert warrior, however; he's just a kid who wants to keep his family together. Bibi starts to cry and says she wants their parents. Someone agrees with her, and they see that it's the boy from before with their ball. His parents are also on the other boat, and he introduces himself as Omar. Jamal feels guilty and invites him to sit with them.

Without his parents, Jamal is forced to take full responsibility for his and his sister's well-being. With the weight of this new responsibility, Jamal proves to be surprisingly capable. While his past solutions to problems have often been impractical—like baking bread to attract his dad—here he acts calmly and practically, asking the smugglers to radio the other boat. Though met with failure, Jamal's efforts underscore his newfound maturity.



Confronted by the harsh reality of his and Bibi's predicament, Jamal begins to act more maturely. Not only does he emphasize the value of patience to Bibi, a quality he himself has struggled with in the past, but his understanding of his relationship to his ancestors also begins to evolve. Recognizing his limitations as a "kid," he stops criticizing himself for falling short of the desert warrior legacy.



CHAPTER 24

Jamal finds their journey to Australia unpleasant. The boat is packed, and people are throwing up a lot, including Omar. Neither Jamal nor Bibi is throwing up, but Omar promises they will be once the waves get big. They also haven't eaten much, having only been given a vegetable tin of water. Jamal isn't hungry because he has a headache, and he misses his parents. Thankfully, two sailors are giving out noodle soup and Jamal and Bibi are next in line.

The person in front of Bibi and Jamal in line for soup is wearing a large blanket. As the person reach for their soup, their sleeve catches on fire in the gas flame. Jamal yells fire and pulls the blanket off the person. Together, he and Bibi stamp out the flames and hand the blanket back to the person. Jamal is shocked to see the person is a teenage girl in a shirt and t-shirt, wearing makeup and green lip-gloss. She thanks Jamal and takes her blanket back.

This passage highlights the difficulties of refugee's lives, particularly refugee children. Though Jamal and Bibi are fortunate to not be throwing up, they are parentless and starving on a boat full of strangers and smugglers. Being young and powerless, they are at the mercy of those around them.



Again, Jamal proves himself to be brave and reliable in a crisis. While others stand around and watch the girl's blanket catch fire, Jamal takes action, saving her life as well as the boat from catching fire. This moment also illustrates Jamal's unfamiliarity with non-conservative female clothing. Though he has been raised to be open-minded and treat girls the same as he'd treat boys, he is still shocked at the sight of a girl in shorts and a t-shirt.



Unfortunately, the sailor serving the food—the sailor in the yellow overalls—refuses to give the girl soup because of the fire, and Bibi yells at him for being unfair. The sailor then refuses to give Jamal and Bibi any food, either. Bibi starts to protest, but the teenage girl stops her, telling her it's more important to make it to Australia safely than to eat. Jamal thanks the teenage girl, who says the sailor probably didn't wash his hands anyway. Jamal decides he likes the girl.

Though Bibi's righteousness here proves troublesome—losing them their soup—it does earn them the teenage girl's friendship. This highlights the upside of Bibi's uncompromising moral activism; though often problematic, Bibi's unwavering righteousness endears some people to her. This passage also highlights Jamal open-mindedness. Though he has never met someone dressed like the girl before, he quickly moves past his shock, appreciating her for who she is.



CHAPTER 25

The girl asks Jamal and Bibi to sit with her. A woman nearby offers them her soup, but Jamal refuses, seeing that she has three small children. The teenage girl jokes to Bibi that the man in yellow overalls needs someone to “teach him a lesson.” She introduces herself as Rashida and Bibi points out that Rashida is a boy's name. Rashida explains that she got her brother's name when he died as a baby. Omar arrives, saying that she must hate her parents. Rashida says she doesn't, explaining that they saved money to buy her a ticket to Australia. She tells Omar to go away, but Jamal explains that Omar is with them.

After the incident with the fire, Jamal, Bibi, and Rashida become better acquainted with one another. This highlights the bond that facing adversity can create between strangers. As parentless children on a smuggler's boat, they already face a lot of the same challenges, and their joint confrontation with the sailor in the yellow overalls cements their bond.



Rashida asks if they have food and they say no, explaining that their parents have all of it. She takes water and sardines out of her pink suitcase and offers some to them. They eat the food and Bibi says she's glad they met her. Jamal says his parents will pay for the food in Australia and offers to teach her a **football** trick in the meantime. Omar keeps on interrupting with annoying comments, but they all ignore him. Jamal and Bibi show Rashida how to bounce the ball from knee to knee. Rashida offers them sunblock, noting how sunburnt they are, and Jamal peeks inside her bag. He excitedly sees flour, realizing it is more valuable to them on the boat.

Rashida proves to be a valuable and generous ally, willingly giving up her food to her new friends. Though Jamal has no food to offer in return, he offers to teach Rashida tricks with the football, reciprocating her generosity and showing his good faith. In this way, the four children begin to form a mini-community on the boat, a chosen family to stand in for their own absent families until they all can be reunited.



CHAPTER 26

Jamal bakes bread using Rashida's flour, draping the loaves on top of the ship's diesel engine. Three sailors are watching him bake it, which makes him nervous. He hopes he used the right ratio of freshwater and seawater—for the salt—so the bread comes out well. The sailors seem impatient for the bread to be ready, so Jamal keeps miming to them that it is not ready yet. He is thankful that Rashida let him use the flour and that her parents thought to pack it. The deck of the boat is filled with water, however, and Jamal is nervous that the boat is leaking. The sailors don't seem to understand his concerns, and he decides not to say anything about it to Bibi or Rashida.

Taking advantage of his new relationship with Rashida, Jamal bakes bread using her flour for the people on the ship. This exemplifies not only his generosity, but also his resourcefulness and cunning. Obviously, he and his sister need food, but so does everyone else on the boat. Baking it for them guarantees him their favor, and as the man in the yellow overalls proved at the soup station, survival is just as much about social dynamics as it is anything else.



CHAPTER 27

Jamal has succeeded in making the bread, but he is now seasick. Still, everyone is enjoying the bread, including Omar and other small kids on the boat. Rashida says the seasickness should wear off in a day, but Omar says it will be closer to a week. Jamal worries Omar is right given how many other people are still sick. Rashida offers Jamal a sip of water, and Omar asks for one too, saying he's also sick. Jamal reminds himself why they're suffering through this experience: to get to Australia. There, the government is nice, and the people are always laughing.

Though his sickness prevents him from eating the bread, Jamal does reap the social benefits of sharing it with the boat. People are happy to be fed, and Jamal is the one responsible for feeding them. This scene also highlights the power of hope. Even though he is suffering from seasickness, Jamal's hopes for Australia sustain him, motivating him to keep moving forward.



CHAPTER 28

Jamal wakes up no longer feeling seasick. He is the first to rise and notices that the boat is no longer running. He thinks it's because they're giving out more noodle soup, but he is wrong. The smugglers ask everyone for an extra hundred dollars, claiming that there was a mistake in the pricing of the tickets, and they need more money to complete the trip. Everyone on the boat starts yelling and crying. The smugglers hold clubs and the sailor in yellow overalls walks around collecting the additional money in a bucket. Those who refuse are threatened and their supplies ransacked.

The smugglers take advantage of their power over the passengers, demanding more money to continue the trip. This highlights the extreme vulnerability of the refugees on the boat: though the smugglers' request is cruel and unjust, the refugees have no choice but to comply. They are entirely dependent on the smugglers to get them to Australia, making resistance futile.



Omar says he has no money, and Jamal realizes that neither do he and Bibi. Jamal tries to offer his remaining loaves of bread to the sailor in the yellow overalls, but the sailor throws them overboard. Rashida pulls out a watch, however, and says it's for four people. Jamal is nervous the sailor will reject it, but he doesn't. Rashida explains that her dad bought it in addition to the ticket, suspecting that something like this might happen. The boat engine starts again, and they resume the journey to Australia. Jamal hopes that if the same thing happens on the other boat, his mom will give up her wedding ring.

As children without parents to pay for their passage, Jamal, Bibi, Rashida, and Omar are particularly vulnerable to the smuggler's scam. Fortunately, Rashida offers to buy off the smugglers for them, using an expensive watch to do so. This underscores not only Rashida's generosity, but also the system of mutual dependence the four children have created. In the absence of their parents, they are forced to rely on one another, creating their own kind of family unit.



CHAPTER 29

Bibi asks Jamal how many days they've been on the boat. She's resting against his arm, and he notices she has a fever. He answers five days, but Rashida corrects him, saying it's six. Jamal thinks Bibi is trying to figure out how much longer they can survive since food ran out that morning. He tells her not to think about the days, but Bibi says it's her birthday. Jamal realizes she is right and apologizes, feeling bad that she is spending her birthday on this boat. They all wish her happy birthday.

This passage emphasizes the emotional and physical challenges of Jamal and Bibi's journey, as well as the increasingly deteriorating conditions on the boat. Not only is their food running out, but things that are normally a cause for celebration—like Bibi's birthday—are unable to be enjoyed or appreciated.



To cheer up Bibi, Jamal suggests they plan a party for her birthday in Australia. Jamal says that the Australian government comes to your house with cake and drinks on your birthday, and Omar and Rashida ask if they bring sardines and hamburgers too. Jamal says yes, but Bibi says she prefers ice cream. Jamal says they have 50 different flavors of ice cream in Australian supermarkets. Omar asks what a supermarket is, and Rashida explains, saying her mom used to love them. She tells them that she used to live in Australia, but when her family traveled to Afghanistan to look after their grandparents, the government wouldn't let them return. Jamal thinks of his own family and feels sad.

While trying to cheer Bibi up by planning an Australian birthday party for her, Rashida shares a glimpse of her own life story. She reveals she is not only originally from Australia, but that her parents are currently stuck in Afghanistan; they had only enough money to send her back home. This reminds Jamal of his own parents and shows Jamal how commonplace it is for parents to sacrifice for their children. Much like Jamal's parents, Rashida's parents are clearly willing to do anything to ensure a better life for their child—even if that life does not include them in it.



CHAPTER 30

People at the front of the boat start screaming and Jamal thinks they heard about how many flavors of ice cream there are in Australia. Instead, he discovers that another boat is approaching. He is excited, but soon realizes that the boat is full of pirates with automatic weapons. The pirates board the boat and the smugglers greet them happily; they are in cahoots. The smugglers join the pirates on their ship, bringing everyone's valuables with them, and Jamal realizes they're being abandoned. Some pirates stay on the ship, however, and begin grabbing women and bringing them onto their ship.

As pirates begin boarding the boat and stealing valuables, the true vulnerability of refugees becomes apparent. They have no defense against armed pirates and have no choice but to watch the pirates steal valuables and abduct women. This harsh reality underscores the dark duality of human nature in the narrative. While many people are generous, extending goodwill towards those who are vulnerable, others are cruel and exploitative, preying on the weak instead of aiding them.



Jamal realizes Bibi and Rashida are in danger and helps them disguise as boys. To ward off suspicion, the three of them start playing with the **football**, hoping that the pirates assume girls can't play football well. A pirate walks by and takes a kick at the football. Jamal pulls the ball away instinctually, and the man misses and falls backward to the ground. The pirate kicks Jamal hard in the hip. Jamal hopes Bibi won't fight back and is glad to see that Omar is holding her back. Rashida rubs Jamal's hip to make it better and when he finally gets up, he sees the pirates are gone. Jamal realizes the only people left are three sailors and the starving refugees.

Fearing Bibi and Rashida will be kidnapped, Jamal devises a clever scheme to ward off suspicion from the pirates, one which uses their misogyny against them. This shows Jamal to be not only socially perceptive, but also incredibly resourceful and quick thinking. It also underscores the sense of mutual responsibility the children feel toward one another. Even Omar, who is normally unhelpful, stops Bibi from hitting the soldier, saving her from being exposed as a girl.



CHAPTER 31

Jamal dreams he is playing on Dubbo Abattoirs United, an Australian **football** team. In the dream, he has the ball, the sun is shining, his parents are there, and everything is good. The goalposts are even made of gold, and the crowd is cheering him on. He wakes up to Bibi screaming against his chest. When he looks up, he understands why: a huge wave is falling on them.

As is often the case when he is under great stress, Jamal dreams of an idyllic future for him and his family. Having just been raided and abandoned by the pirates, Jamal clearly yearns to escape from the reality he is living in—one that seems to be getting more dangerous by the minute.



CHAPTER 32

Jamal loses Omar and Rashida, but not Bibi. Their belts are tied together, and they are scooping water with vegetable tins below deck. The water is up to Jamal's waist and Bibi says it's hopeless. Jamal says they're making progress, even though they are clearly not. The water is coming in faster than everyone can scoop it out. Bibi says they need to tell the sailors the boat is sinking, but Jamal doesn't have the heart to tell her that the sailors are already below deck. Jamal is miserable, but he draws inspiration from his dad's ancestors and their tireless persistence baking bread. Bibi keeps working too, impressing the men around them. Jamal knows she's able to work so hard because her dad is a baker.

For the first time in the story, Jamal recognizes the value of his baker ancestors, elevating them to the same status as his desert warrior ancestors. What makes the bakers special, he realizes, is their persistence and their ingenuity—qualities Jamal has exhibited throughout his journey without attributing them to his baker ancestors. Now, he proudly recognizes the same qualities in his sister, signaling Jamal's relinquishment of his former way of thinking about identity and ancestry. While he used to think his sister got all the desert warrior genes, he begins to believe they each inherited qualities from both sides of the family.



CHAPTER 33

Jamal hears people screaming above deck but can't understand what they're saying. Jamal doesn't want to see because he doesn't want anything else bad to be happening. Rashida calls for him to come up and Jamal is thankful she is alive. He and Bibi climb to the deck and see a huge warship with its guns pointing at them. People on the boat are scared and are yelling not to shoot because there are babies on board. Jamal is not scared, however, because he recognizes the flag on the ship as Australia's. He starts to laugh and cry and tells Bibi and Rashida the good news.

Exhausted from the unending tragedies, Jamal does not want to see what's happening on deck. He has been conditioned to interpret commotion as bad news and cannot stand to face another problem. This illustrates the psychological effect that trauma can have long-term. Jamal's natural curiosity and optimism have been worn out, leaving him jaded.



CHAPTER 34

Jamal sees an Australian serviceman looking into his cabin on the Australian warship. He recognizes him as Andrew, the kind Australian man who carried him and Bibi onto the warship earlier. Andrew asks if Jamal is awake, and then he checks to see that Bibi's fever is gone; it is. He has food with him because he thought they might still be hungry—they ate their last meal so quickly, he thought they were starved. Andrew apologizes to Jamal, and Jamal asks if something has happened to their parents. Andrew says no, explaining that their parents' boat likely took a different route and that a plane is out looking for it.

After their harrowing experience on the smuggler's boat, Jamal and Bibi finally find relief on the Australian warship. Though they are not in Australia yet and have not reunited with their parents, they have enough food to eat and a comfortable place to sleep. In Andrew, they also find an adult who cares for them and who they can trust; for the first time since leaving Afghanistan, they believe they can relax.



Andrew explains that he is sorry because it took so long to get everyone off the boat, saying there was "paperwork." Andrew then asks after Jamal's hip, saying it should be X-rayed, but they don't have one on the ship. Jamal doesn't know what an X-ray is, imagining it to be a traditional Australian method of curing bruises. Andrews turns to leave, but Jamal does not want him to go. He asks where Andrew learned his language and Andrew tells him he attended night school. Jamal has lots of questions but decides to prioritize asking about Rashida. Andrew says she is fine, she's just dehydrated.

Andrew proves himself to be a kind and compassionate caretaker of Jamal and Bibi. Having fended for themselves for so long on the smuggler's boat, Andrew is a welcome figure in their lives, providing much-needed solace. While he cannot replace their parents, he is able to provide them with a degree of comfort and safety that they had been unable to provide themselves. In this way, Andrew is a stark contrast to smugglers and pirates from before, emphasizing the good side of humanity.



Jamal is scared to ask whether Omar has been found yet. Andrew says he has not, but that he will show up, along with his ball. Andrew starts to leave, and Jamal says he hopes that Australian government brings him a big cake when it's his birthday. Andrew looks confused and Jamal suspects he does not fully understand how birthdays work in Australia. As Jamal eats, a voice speaks to him from the doorway. He hears a **football** bouncing and realizes it's Omar. Omar asks if the food for Bibi is for him.

Jamal continues to show how much he cares for his new chosen family when he works up the courage to ask about Omar. His family, interestingly, also seems to have taken precedence over soccer—Andrew is the one to bring up Jamal's missing football, rather than Jamal. Jamal's misunderstanding about Australian birthdays also emphasizes the potential humor in cross-cultural interactions.



CHAPTER 35

Jamal believes they are almost in Australia. They're in one of the warships' rubber boats heading to the coastline, and Jamal notices how green Australia looks. Neither he nor Bibi see his parents or their boat, however. There are people waiting for them on land, but when they arrive, they still don't see their parents. Jamal feels panicky and Bibi begins to cry, but Andrew reassures them that they will find the other boat. Jamal believes him and begins to revel in being in Australia.

Reaching what he believes is Australia, Jamal is forced to confront the contrast between his expectations and his reality. Though he and Bibi have made to the land they dreamed of, they have arrived without their parents. Thus, the moment is bittersweet; while it spells the end of their harrowing journey, it is still not the resolution they hoped for.



Andrew leads everyone into a compound with massive tents. He tells them this is their home and tries to separate males from females, but Jamal says they're all staying together: he, Bibi, Omar, and Rashida. Andrew allows it, and they all get a tent together. Bibi still looks sad, and Jamal suggests they explore Australia to cheer her up. Andrew gives Jamal a weird look, however, and Jamal thinks Andrew is judging him for being selfish: their parents are not there yet, and it would be mean to have fun without them. Reflecting on how kind Australians are, Jamal thanks Andrew silently for his unspoken insight.

Having yet to reunite with their parents, Jamal and the other children stick together in the compound. Though the Australians want to separate them by gender, Jamal, Bibi, Rashida, and Omar all refuse, illustrating the depth of their bond. This moment also hints that something might be amiss. Though Jamal interprets Andrew's weird look as admonishment for his perceived selfishness, Jamal often misreads situations, so readers should assume there's more going on than Jamal realizes.



CHAPTER 36

Jamal and the other refugees play a **football** game against the "Aussies." It is Andrew's idea, and Jamal is having a lot of fun. Omar is not having a good time, however, and Jamal thinks it might be because he's not very good. Omar asks Jamal if he has heard what the people are saying about the camp, but Jamal ignores him and focuses on the football. They continue playing and, despite his hip pain, Jamal scores a goal. Instead of the crowd cheering, however, there's silence. Then people begin to scream and sob, and Jamal finds out the other boat has sunk.

Distracted by the football game with the Aussies, Jamal fails to notice the rumors circulating camp about the other boat sinking. This illustrates both the positive and negative side of distraction: though the football game allows Jamal to have peace of mind a little longer, it also blinds him to a reality that everyone else is already aware of.



CHAPTER 37

Jamal looks for Andrew, but then he remembers Andrew is on the warship. Instead, he runs over to a group of Australian soldiers. He explains that they need to send a rescue boat out, but the Australians don't speak his language and don't know what he's saying. Jamal draws in the dust to explain, but the men just stare. Jamal screams at them, saying he cannot believe people are like this in Australia. The man repeats the word "Australia" back to him questioningly, and then he draws in the dust. The man draws a big island and a smaller island. He points to the big island and says "Australia," and then points to the other island, saying: "Here, not Australia."

Like when he and Bibi were first separated from his parents, Jamal takes immediate action after hearing his parents' boat sank, begging soldiers to send out a rescue boat. This underscores Jamal's unwavering optimism and initiative; instead of assuming his parents are dead or that someone else will deal with the problem, Jamal attempts to solve the problem himself. However, none of the soldiers seem able to help, and Jamal is told that the island they are on is not actually Australia.



CHAPTER 38

Rashida brings dinner to Jamal and Bibi in the tent. Jamal does not want to answer, or eat, or talk to Rashida. He just wants his parents. Rashida reports that the warship did everything they could, searching for hours. Jamal thinks if only they had kept the **candlestick**, they could have lit a candle, and the rescuers might have found his parents. Jamal wishes he and Bibi were in a government jail instead of their parents dead at the bottom of the ocean.

Jamal and Bibi reach their lowest point so far in their journey. Believing their parents to be dead, neither of them want to eat or talk or do anything, illustrating the devastating physical and emotional effect that loss can have on a person. Though Rashida is incredibly supportive and sympathetic, she can do nothing to ease their grief.



Rashida gives Jamal his **football**, saying it got punctured earlier on a barbed wire fence. Rashida sits in silence and then tells Jamal and Bibi that even though their parents are gone, they still have her. Jamal thanks her, but her words only makes him feel a little better, like how almost drowning made him feel better. Rashida leaves, and Jamal says to himself that it's just him and Bibi.

Jamal learns his football got punctured during the most recent football game—a metaphor for the emotional devastation Jamal feels after learning of his parent's death. Like his football, Jamal's hopes and dreams have been punctured and deflated, leaving him with nothing.



CHAPTER 39

Jamal lies on the **football** field planning his and Bibi's future. He does not want to, but as the older child he feels it is his responsibility. Omar calls to Jamal and Jamal notices his voice is wobbly, which is unusual for him. Jamal remembers his parents were also on the boat and feels bad for forgetting; he realizes grief can make you selfish. Omar lies next to him and tells him his parents were not on the boat—they died when he was two. They sit in silence and then Jamal asks how he got a ticket to Australia. Omar explains that he hid on the bus and the plane, pretending to be with a family.

Despite his youth, Jamal displays incredible maturity here. Though he too is suffering, he tries to plan for his and Bibi's future, following in his parent's footsteps. Just as they suppressed their own suffering for the sake of their children, Jamal suppresses his own pain to take care of Bibi. Jamal also reads as incredibly mature as he begins to think more sympathetically about Omar—while Omar reveals that Jamal, Bibi, and Rashida are perhaps the first family he's had in a long time.



Jamal is impressed by Omar's independence and thinks about what he and Bibi could do alone. He thinks that if they traveled around, meeting losing Australian **football** teams and explaining their situation, the players might feel better about their own situations and let them train with them. Omar shamefully tells Jamal his ancestors were thieves. Jamal thinks back on Omar stealing his football, but then thinks of all the nice things he did, like keeping Bibi from attacking the pirate. Jamal realizes it's never so simple as to be just one thing. Omar asks him who his ancestors were, and Jamal tells him. Jamal says he is a bit of both of his ancestors.

Jamal realizes that one's identity is not necessarily determined by who one's ancestors are. Just as Omar is not necessarily a thief because his ancestors were, so too is Jamal not necessarily just a desert warrior or a baker; a person does not just have to be just one thing. This revelation highlights Jamal's newfound maturity and emotional development. His understanding of the world has become more complex, as has his understanding of himself.



CHAPTER 40

Jamal dreams of scoring a goal for Manchester United. Bibi, who is also on the team, gives him a hug, as do his parents. He feels good, but when he wakes up, he remembers everything and feels bad again. Bibi shakes Jamal to get up and Jamal instinctually assumes someone has stepped on a **landmine**. He figures no one told them about there being landmines because they did not want to upset orphans like them. Jamal is not worried, however, because he has a plan: he'll cry for two hours a day and then be a productive Australian citizen the rest of the time.

Like after the pirates raided the ship, Jamal dreams of an alternative world in which his family is reunited, and where everyone is happy. Upon waking, however, Jamal does not shirk from responsibility. He confronts the reality of his predicament, showing remarkable maturity and resilience. Acknowledging his need for mourning, he decides to cry for two hours a day, but work hard the rest to support him and Bibi—which is humorous and also profoundly sad.



People are shouting, but Jamal realizes the shouts sound too happy for them to be about a **landmine**. He and Bibi run outside and see the warship is back. Jamal realizes they must be bringing back the survivors and follows Bibi down to the jetty. People climb out of the boat and Jamal is confused who all of them are. He sees Omar hugging a big family and thinks he must be dreaming. Jamal sees a man break down after receiving news from an officer and realizes that news has come back about who drowned. Bibi screams excitedly and Jamal turns to see his parents. His mom explains the warship didn't see them at first, but then they did. The family embraces.

Just as soon as Jamal accepts his parents' death, abandoning all hope of their return, they arrive by surprise on the Australian warship. This highlights Jamal's complicated relationship to hope and optimism. Though he is consistently the most hopeful character in the story, it is he who is most shocked by his parent's return.



CHAPTER 41

Jamal and his family hug until the sun comes up. Eventually they return to their tent and talk. Jamal's dad reveals that the island is not Australia; it's an island in the Pacific Ocean. Their parents ask Jamal and Bibi about their journey and their mom calls the sailor in yellow overalls a "selfish camel-snot." Bibi says that Rashida says some people are "camel snots" because of what has happened to them. They introduce their parents to Omar and Rashida, and their parents hug and thank them for their help. Jamal explains his and Bibi's plans to become famous **football** players and create a new government back in Afghanistan. Their parents look happy and begin to cry.

Reunited at last, Jamal and his family revel in one another's presence. They have not seen each other since being separated on the boats and have much to share about their journeys. Despite their happiness of all being together, Jamal and Bibi still take the time to introduce their parents to Omar and Rashida, not forgetting the people who helped them along the way. This suggests that the bonds they formed on their journey will be lasting ones, emphasizing how strong bonds formed under adversity can be.



CHAPTER 42

In his office, Andrew tells Jamal how happy he is for him. Jamal starts to ask a question, but Andrew interrupts him, apologizing for not telling him earlier that the island is not Australia. Jamal says he understands and asks why they brought them here. Andrew explains, uncomfortably, that his country has changed its stance on immigration after their most recent election. Jamal realizes some Australians don't want people like him and his family in Australia. Andrew gives Jamal his **football** back, saying he mended it. Jamal thanks Andrew, giving Andrew a significant look so that he knows he is thankful for more than just the football.

Given how kind Andrew is, Jamal is confused why some Australians don't want people from Afghanistan moving there. Andrew tells Jamal to give the ball a try. Jamal doesn't feel like it, but he does anyway to make Andrew feel better. When he tries to do a trick, however, his knee bursts into pain and the ball smashes through the window. Jamal apologizes, but Andrew is more concerned about him getting medical attention than the window. He bemoans that there is no X-ray on the island with them.

Andrew looks sad and explains that he hates what his country is doing to people like Jamal. Jamal sees that Andrew is trying to control his feelings, but he's failing, and a tear rolls down his face. Jamal pats his arm and says he is glad Andrew is there. Jamal understands how Andrew feels. He knows what it's like to have a dream and have it turn out to be harder than you thought. He tells Andrew the secret of **football** is never giving up, even if it seems hopeless. Andrew smiles at Jamal and Jamal smiles back, telling him everything will be ok. Jamal looks out the window and sees his family happily walking along the beach. Jamal feels lucky and full of love. Even though they're not in Australia, Jamal feels like they are.

Jamal and Andrew have a heart to heart. Despite their many differences, the two of them have bonded over the course of their time together and Andrew feels he owes Jamal an explanation for lying about Australia. Being the understanding person he is, Jamal quickly forgives Andrew, feeling grateful for Andrew's kindness.



Though Jamal has matured a lot since first leaving Afghanistan, he is still too naïve to understand the politics of immigration. Being the kind-hearted person he is, he fails to understand why a country would ban a particular type of person from immigrating there. Essentially, Jamal would never discriminate against someone for their race or nationality, and so he struggles to imagine someone who would.



Ironically, it is Jamal who ends up consoling Andrew. Though Jamal does not fully understand what Andrew is upset about, he is a naturally sympathetic person and tries to cheer him up, telling Andrew the secret of football is to never give up. Andrew is touched by Jamal's simple yet optimistic message, likely because he knows the struggles Jamal has gone through recently; for Jamal to maintain such a positive attitude shows incredible resilience of spirit. This passage also underscores Jamal's newfound maturity. While he once idealized Australia as the perfect home, he now understands that what really matters is family. Essentially, Jamal begins to think of Australia as a happy state of mind rather than a place—and with this view, Australia can be anywhere as long as his family is there, too.





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